A DISSERTATION



Stone *and Light*

Lapidary Humanism and the Ethics of the Held Form in Rebecca Sugar's Steven Universe (2013–2020)

October 11, 2026

LAPIDARY HUMANISM · THE HELD FORM

Abstract

THIS DISSERTATION ARGUES that Rebecca Sugar's *Steven Universe* (Cartoon Network, 2013–2019), together with *Steven Universe: The Movie* (2019) and the epilogue series *Steven Universe Future* (2019–2020), constitutes not merely a landmark of queer and feminist representation in children's animation but a sustained work of speculative philosophical anthropology: a fictional ontology whose rules of embodiment, union, injury, and repair amount to an answer to humanism's founding question of what a person is and on what basis a person may claim dignity. Reading the series' diegetic metaphysics—gemstone cores projecting bodies of hard light; fusion by synchronized dance; regeneration, bubbling, corruption, shattering, and healing—as a philosophical proposal rather than as decorative allegory, the study reconstructs the genealogies the show mobilizes, from Aristophanes' speech in the *Symposium*, Aristotle's doctrine of the natural slave, and Pico della Mirandola's *Oration* to Spinoza's composite individuals, Buber's I–Thou, Fromm's distinction between symbiotic union and mature love, Beauvoir's ethics of ambiguity, Arendt's natality, Freire's pedagogy of the oppressed, and Winnicott's holding environment. It situates these within feminist, queer, Black feminist, decolonial, disability, and new-materialist thought (Lorde, hooks, Irigaray, Ruddick, Kittay, Tronto, Benjamin, Butler, Sedgwick, Haraway, Barad, Malabou, Anzaldúa, Fanon, Spivak, Kafer) and within a comparative corpus of feminist speculative fiction (Gilman, Le Guin, Russ, Piercy, Octavia E. Butler) and Japanese animation (Takeuchi, Ikuhara, Miyazaki, Toriyama).

Against representational readings that measure the series chiefly by the visibility of its queer couples, the dissertation advances an original thesis, which it names *lapidary humanism*. The Gem body, it argues, models personhood as a dialectic of *stone* and *light*: a minimal, durable, woundable core that carries continuity, memory, and accountability without carrying a destiny, and a projected, revisable form through which the person appears, relates, and changes. From this dialectic the series derives an *ethics of the held form*, organized by four principles—**revocability** (a union is legitimate only while it remains withdrawable by those who compose it), **holding** (revision requires an environment that sustains the subject while it is formless), **continuity** (repair must not erase the history inscribed in the stone), and **reciprocity** (care that does not circulate becomes sacrifice)—and by four corresponding pathologies: captive fusion, unheld or destructive plasticity, erasure, and sacrificial holding. All four converge in Homeworld's master pathology, *petrification*: the reduction of persons to assigned function.

The dissertation demonstrates, first, that consent operates in the series as an ontogenetic rather than a merely regulative category, since fused persons exist only for as long as consent sustains them; second, that the revelation of Rose Quartz's identity as Pink Diamond converts a heroic matrilineal myth into a Kleinian problem of integration and a Derridean problem of inheritance, resolved not by filiation but by Arendtian

natality; third, that the series' contested reconciliation with the Diamonds both enacts and strains a Freirean and restorative model of justice; and fourth, that *Steven Universe Future* functions as an immanent critique of the show's own savior ethic, relocating its protagonist from the infinite responsibility of the Levinasian subject to the reciprocal dependencies theorized by care ethics. A concluding synthesis argues that animation—an art of projected light sustained by collective labor—is the medium in which lapidary humanism becomes thinkable, and proposes the *lapidary polis* as a model of association grounded in exit, voice, and revocable belonging. The study closes by setting against Foucault's image of "man" as a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea a different figure supplied by the series itself: a face carved in stone at the edge of the sea, composed of many, and held in common.

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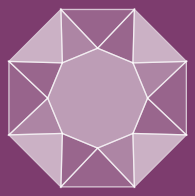
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The Question of the Gem

0.1 A Cartoon as Philosophical Anthropology

EVERY HUMANISM BEGINS with an image of the body that is also a theory of its worth. Pico della Mirandola's Adam is set down at the center of creation without a fixed seat, form, or office, so that his dignity lies in the freedom to fashion himself upward toward the angels or downward toward the beasts; Kant's rational being is honored because it legislates the moral law to itself; Sartre's human reverses the order of the manufactured paper-knife, existing first and acquiring an essence only through its projects. *Steven Universe* begins with a different image: a gemstone that projects a body of light. Its Gems are not organisms but emanations. Their bodies are hard-light projections sustained by a mineral core; injury disperses them ("poofing") and returns them to the stone, from which they re-project after an interval of withdrawal, frequently in revised form. They can be cracked (wounded), shattered (killed), corrupted (deformed by a weaponized trauma into monstrous and incommunicative shapes), bubbled (suspended in a sphere that is at once sanctuary and cell), and fused (merged through synchronized movement into a third person who is both and neither of the participants). Against them stand the human beings of Beach City—mortal, organic, singular—and between them stands the protagonist, Steven, the only being of his kind: the child of a human musician and of a Gem whose stone he carries in his navel.

The central claim of this dissertation is that these rules are not the arbitrary machinery of a fantasy cartoon but a coherent speculative ontology with determinate ethical consequences, and that the series works out those consequences across nearly two hundred episodes with a rigor that warrants its treatment as philosophy rather than as an illustration of philosophy. The precedent is Stanley Cavell's insistence that certain Hollywood comedies do not merely depict but *think* the conditions of marriage and conversation (Cavell 1981), together with Ursula K. Le Guin's description of science fiction as a mode of thought-experiment that describes the present by varying its constants (Le Guin 1976) and Donna Haraway's account of "SF"—speculative fabulation, string figures, speculative feminism—as a practice for imagining livable worlds (Haraway 2016). *Steven Universe* philosophizes in the medium of the animated

body. Its arguments are conducted through what bodies can do, what they can become, with whom, and under what conditions they may cease to be.

The stakes of this claim are partly polemical. The series' reception, popular and scholarly, has been organized largely around representation: the courtship and wedding of Ruby and Sapphire in "Reunited" (2018), widely reported as among the first same-gender weddings depicted in an American children's animated series; the nonbinary fusion Stevonnie and, later, the nonbinary character Shep; and the show's candor about consent, anxiety, grief, and therapy. These achievements are real and are not diminished here. A representational frame nonetheless treats the work as content to be audited against standards formulated elsewhere, and it tends to stop at the threshold of the work's own thinking. The present study asks the prior question: what does the world of *Steven Universe* imply about personhood, union, power, harm, and repair, and how do those implications revise the traditions—humanist, feminist, queer, decolonial, psychoanalytic—on which the series draws?

0.2 Corpus, Authorship, and Production

The primary corpus comprises the original series (five broadcast seasons, November 2013 to January 2019, following a pilot released online in 2013), *Steven Universe: The Movie* (September 2019), and the twenty-episode epilogue *Steven Universe Future* (December 2019 to March 2020). Episodes are cited by title, with *Future* episodes marked SUF and the feature marked SU:TM; songs are referred to by title, and dialogue is paraphrased rather than transcribed. The two production companions edited by Chris McDonnell (2017; 2019) supply design history but are not treated as interpretive authorities.

Rebecca Sugar (born 1987, Silver Spring, Maryland) trained in animation at the School of Visual Arts in New York and came to prominence as a storyboard artist and songwriter on Pendleton Ward's *Adventure Time*, where her songs for the character Marceline established the confessional, melodically plain idiom that would become her signature. *Steven Universe* made her, by wide report, the first woman to create a Cartoon Network series independently. She named the protagonist after her younger brother, Steven Sugar, an artist on the series, and has described the show as an attempt to imagine a boy raised by, and identifying with, powerful women. In 2018 Sugar publicly described herself as a nonbinary woman and characterized the Gems in comparable terms. That statement is cited here not as a biographical key that unlocks the text but as an index of its stakes: the Gems' femininity is a mode of appearance without a reproductive substrate, a gender that is neither grounded in sex nor reducible to costume, and the series' central experiments with form presuppose exactly this decoupling.

Authorship in television animation is collective, and the series' collective mode of production bears directly on its philosophy. The so-called Crewniverse—among them Ian Jones-Quartey, Kat Morris, Joe Johnston, Lamar Abrams, Hilary Florido, Jeff Liu, Hellen Jo, Danny Cragg, Paul Villeco, Katie Mitroff, Raven Molisee, Matt Burnett, and Ben Levin—worked within a board-driven system in which storyboard artists wrote episodes visually, typically in credited pairs; the score by Aivi & Surasshu fused chiptune, folk, and orchestral idioms; and a voice cast including Zach Callison, Estelle, Deedee Magno Hall, Michaela Dietz, Susan Egan, Uzo Aduba, Patti LuPone, Lisa Hannigan, and Christine Ebersole gave the series its unusual musical-theatrical texture. Chapter Six argues that the paired authorship of episodes is not incidental: a series about fusion was itself made by fusion.

The series' formal lineage is equally plural. It inherits the transformation sequences, team structures, and redemptive pacifism of Naoko Takeuchi's *Sailor Moon*, which Sugar has repeatedly named as formative; it rewrites the martial fusion dance of Akira Toriyama's *Dragon Ball Z* as a choreography of intimacy; it engages, in its rose iconography and its figure of the owned and silenced servant, Kunihiko Ikuhara's *Revolutionary Girl Utena*; and it shares with Hayao Miyazaki's *Nausicaä of the Valley of the Wind* the conviction that the monstrous is often the wounded. Its setting transposes this inheritance onto the off-season Americana of a Delmarva-style boardwalk town, with its donut shop, fry stand, pizzeria, and arcade. Throughout, the dissertation distinguishes documented influence, which is rare and stated as such, from structural affinity, which is the main object of comparison. No claim is made that the series' makers read Simondon or Kittay; the claim is that the series thinks problems those writers named.

0.3 Method: Speculative-Ontological and Reparative Reading

Three methodological commitments govern what follows. The first is *speculative-ontological reading*. The series' diegetic rules are treated as axioms whose implications can be derived, tested against cases, and compared with philosophical positions, in the manner in which analytic philosophy treats its thought experiments. The comparison is exact rather than loose: Derek Parfit's cases of fission and fusion in *Reasons and Persons* (1984), designed to show that personal identity is not what matters in survival, find in the series a world in which fusion is a routine social practice and in which, consequently, the question of what persists through union must be answered in everyday life. Where the analytic tradition holds its cases at the level of stipulation, the series inhabits them, follows them across years, and lets them acquire histories, injuries, and marriages.

The second commitment is *comparative-genealogical*. Each of the series' core propositions is located within intellectual lineages that run from classical antiquity through Renaissance and Enlightenment humanism, existentialism, psychoanalysis, and the feminist, queer, Black feminist, decolonial, disability, and new-materialist theory of the late twentieth and early twenty-first centuries, and within a parallel lineage of feminist speculative fiction from Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Herland* (1915) to Octavia E. Butler's *Xenogenesis* (1987–1989). The purpose is not to inflate a cartoon with borrowed prestige but to discover where its propositions agree with, depart from, or correct those traditions.

The third commitment is methodological as well as ethical. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick distinguished a *paranoid* hermeneutics, which anticipates and exposes complicity so that nothing will surprise it, from a *reparative* practice that seeks to assemble from damaged objects something that can sustain the reader (Sedgwick 2003). The present study practices reparative reading without forfeiting critique. Its fourth chapter stages a sustained paranoid objection to the series—that its reconciliation with the Diamonds launders imperial power through the idiom of family therapy—and gives that objection its full force before evaluating it. A series that is itself so preoccupied with the difference between repairing and erasing harm can be read faithfully only by a method that refuses both credulity and contempt. To these commitments is added close formal attention to animation as a medium: to the projected, revisable, collectively drawn body that the Gem literalizes (Eisenstein 1986; Wells 1998; Crafton 2013).

0.4 The Argument in Brief

The dissertation's original thesis is that *Steven Universe* proposes a *lapidary humanism*. The Gem body models personhood as a dialectic of *stone* and *light*. The stone is a minimal, durable, woundable core: it carries continuity, memory, and accountability; it can be cracked and shattered; but it carries no destiny, since the "purpose" for which Homeworld manufactures each Gem is a social imposition rather than a property of the mineral. The light is a projected, revisable form through which the person appears, acts, relates, and changes. Neither pole suffices. Stone without light is petrification—essence without becoming, function without freedom—and this is the condition Homeworld imposes on its subjects. Light without stone, or light whose stone has been violated, is destructive plasticity—becoming without continuity, form exploded by trauma—and this is the condition of corruption. Personhood is the held form between them: a revocable projection of light from a wounded stone, sustained in common.

Personhood is the held form between them: a revocable projection of light from a wounded stone, sustained in common.

From this dialectic the series derives an ethics organized by four principles, each with a corresponding pathology. *Revocability* holds that a union, whether a fusion, a marriage, or a polity, is legitimate only while those who compose it can withdraw; its violation is *captive fusion*, figured by the forced fusions of shattered Gems and by the colossal Cluster. *Holding* holds that revision requires an environment that sustains the subject while it is formless, as the bubble sustains the retreated Gem; its violation is *abandonment* and its consequence *unheld plasticity*, figured by corruption and by Spinel's six-thousand-year wait in a garden. *Continuity* holds that repair must not erase the history inscribed in the stone; its violation is *erasure*, figured by the Rejuvenator, by the myth of Pink Diamond's shattering, and by every attempt to restore a person by forgetting what was done to her. *Reciprocity* holds that care which does not circulate becomes sacrifice; its violation is *sacrificial holding*, figured by Rose Quartz's self-erasure into her son and by that son's collapse, in *Future*, under a responsibility no one shared with him.

The chapters proceed as follows. Chapter One reconstructs Homeworld as a metaphysics of fixed form, reading the Kindergarten through Sartre's paper-knife, Aristotle's ergon and natural slave, Plato's noble lie, and the logic of colonial extraction, and argues that the series' all-feminine empire is a deliberate refusal of the cultural-feminist premise that rule by women would be benign. Chapter Two argues that fusion makes consent ontogenetic: fused persons exist only while consent sustains them, so that the series converts the moral theory of consent into an ontology, which the chapter situates between Aristophanes' myth of the other half, Spinoza's composite individuals, Buber, Simondon, and Barad, and between Hobbes's Leviathan and the feminist critique of contract. Chapter Three reads the revelation that Rose Quartz was Pink Diamond as a problem of matrilineal inheritance, drawing on Irigaray, Klein, Hirsch, Memmi, Nietzsche, Derrida, and Arendt to argue that Steven escapes his mother's ledger not by repudiation but by natality. Chapter Four evaluates the series' nonviolence and its reconciliation with the Diamonds against Fanon, Freire, Butler, Arendt, and the restorative-justice tradition, conceding the force of the charge that reconciliation came without redistribution. Chapter Five reads the series' psychology of

affect and trauma, culminating in *Steven Universe Future* as an immanent critique of the show's own savior ethic in the light of care ethics, trauma theory, and Malabou's destructive plasticity. Chapter Six turns to the ordinary: Beach City's chosen kinships, Little Homeworld's diasporic hybridity, the series' songs, and its paired production. Chapter Seven assembles the synthesis: lapidary humanism as a resolution of the impasse between essentialist and constructionist accounts of the person, animation as its proper medium, the refusal of the Omelas settlement in which a community's happiness is purchased by a child's suffering, and the lapidary polis as a model of association grounded in exit, voice, and revocable belonging.

CHAPTER ONE

01

Made for a Purpose

Homeworld and the Metaphysics of Fixed Form

HOMEWORLD IS THE series' theory of domination, and its first premise is that a person can be manufactured for a use. This chapter reconstructs that premise and its consequences in four registers—metaphysical, political, gendered, and colonial—and concludes by naming the pathology in which they converge.

1.1 The Kindergarten and the Artifactual Subject

Gems are not born; they are grown. Homeworld seeds a planet's crust with injectors, and each Gem incubates in rock, drawing the vitality of the surrounding world into itself until it emerges from a cavity shaped to its body, leaving behind a cliff-face pocked with human-shaped exits and a landscape drained of life. Earth's Prime Kindergarten, to which Amethyst leads Steven in "On the Run" to show him the hole from which she came, is at once a nursery and a quarry: a site of birth that is indistinguishable from a site of extraction. Each Gem emerges as an instance of a type, and each type is defined by a function. Quartzes are soldiers; Rubies are guards; Sapphires are aristocratic seers; Pearls are ornamental servants; Lapis Lazulis terraform; Bismuths build; Peridots maintain technology; Agates supervise; Zircons argue cases before the Diamonds in "The Trial." The Gem's purpose is fixed before it exists.

This is, with a precision that is almost diagrammatic, the condition Jean-Paul Sartre assigned to the artifact in *Existentialism Is a Humanism* (1946). The artisan who makes a paper-knife works from a concept of what a paper-knife is and what it is for; in the artifact, essence precedes existence. The human being, Sartre argued, inverts this order: it exists first, encounters itself, and defines itself afterward through its acts. Homeworld is a civilization that refuses the inversion and manufactures persons as if they were paper-knives. The Crystal Gem rebellion is, in this light, the political form of existentialism: the claim, made by beings who were literally fabricated according to a concept, that their existence nonetheless precedes and exceeds the concept.

The series does not, however, simply ratify Sartre. Sartrean freedom is radical and solitary; it is a condition one cannot escape and for whose evasion, through bad faith, one is culpable. The series' freed Gems do not experience freedom as a sudden metaphysical fact but as a slow, situated, and frequently relapsing achievement. Pearl, millennia after the rebellion, still seeks commands, still measures herself by her service to an absent sovereign, and still flinches into deference. Her condition is better described by Simone de Beauvoir's correction of Sartre in *The Ethics of Ambiguity* (1947) and *The Second Sex* (1949): that freedom is always exercised from within a situation, that oppression can install itself in the oppressed as habit, posture, and desire, and that the freedom of any one person is bound up with the freedom of others. Homeworld's subjects are not guilty of bad faith when they cling to their functions; they are living out a situation in which function has been made the condition of being recognized at all.

The classical source of Homeworld's ethics is older still. Aristotle grounds the human good in the *ergon* argument of *Nicomachean Ethics* I.7: just as the good of the flautist lies in fluting well, the good of each thing lies in the excellent performance of its characteristic function. Homeworld universalizes this reasoning and applies it caste by caste. A Gem's virtue is the competent execution of its role; its vice is deviation. Jasper, who prides herself on being a flawless Quartz and dismisses Amethyst as a stunted and defective one, is the series' most complete Aristotelian, and her tragedy is that of a creature who has no account of her own worth that is not an account of her performance. When, in *Future*'s "Fragments," she demands that Steven defeat her in combat and then seeks to serve him, she reveals that a being formed entirely by ergon-ethics cannot imagine a relation other than rank.

1.2 The Noble Lie in Mineral: Plato, Aristotle, and the Pearl as Living Instrument

Plato's *Republic* proposes that the founders of the just city tell its citizens a "noble lie" (414b–415d): that they were fashioned and nurtured beneath the earth, which is their mother, and that the god who formed them mixed gold into the rulers, silver into the auxiliaries, and iron and bronze into the farmers and craftsmen, so that each class is fitted by nature to its station. The correspondence with the Kindergarten is exact in both of its elements. Gems are formed beneath the earth and emerge from it; their social rank is identical with their material composition. What Plato offered as a myth for the purpose of stabilizing hierarchy, Homeworld has made literal. The series thereby performs a philosophical experiment of considerable elegance. It asks what would follow if the noble lie were true—if persons really were made of different substances suited to different roles—and answers that hierarchy would still not be justified. The Crystal Gems, composed of the same materials as their Homeworld counterparts, demonstrate in every episode that constitution does not dictate vocation. The argument is a narrative refutation of the naturalistic fallacy at the level of political theory: no *is*, however literal, yields the *ought* of subordination.

> *No is, however literal, yields the ought of subordination.*

Aristotle's *Politics* supplies the second classical template. The slave, Aristotle argues (I.4–5, 1253b–1255a), is a "living instrument," a possession that acts, and some beings are slaves by nature because they participate in reason only enough to apprehend it, not to possess it. Homeworld's Pearls are the purest

figure of this doctrine in contemporary fiction. They are made to serve, to stand ornamentally beside their owners, to speak when addressed, and to be given, traded, or reassigned; one Pearl was transferred from Pink Diamond to White Diamond after Pink, in a fit of rage, cracked her eye. A Pearl's obedience is not merely enjoined but constitutive: a direct order from her Diamond binds her physically.

The series' Pearl, Steven's guardian, is the bondsman who became a warrior, and her arc reads as a dramatization of the lord–bondsman dialectic of Hegel's *Phenomenology of Spirit* (1807, §§178–196), in which self-consciousness emerges in the servant through fear, discipline, and the formative labor by which she shapes the world and, in shaping it, discovers herself. A Pearl who fights is, in Homeworld's terms, a category error; Pearl's swordsmanship is the labor through which she became something no Pearl was supposed to be. Yet the series withholds the Hegelian consolation that the servant's self-consciousness will in time supersede the master's. Pearl's liberation remains bound to her devotion to Rose, and the devotion is itself the residue of servitude. The deepest figure of this bind is the revelation of "A Single Pale Rose," in which it emerges that Pearl had been ordered by Pink Diamond never to speak of what she knew. Pearl does not refuse to tell; she cannot. Her hand rises to cover her own mouth. Gayatri Chakravorty Spivak's question—whether the subaltern can speak—receives here its most literal answer (Spivak 1988). The subaltern is not voiceless; she is structurally interdicted, and her speech becomes possible only when the command that binds it is lifted from outside.

Above these templates stands the oldest ordering image of Western metaphysics, the great chain of being that Arthur O. Lovejoy traced from Plato to the eighteenth century (Lovejoy 1936): a continuous hierarchy of kinds, every link occupied, every being in its place. Homeworld is a chain of being administered as an empire, with the Diamonds at its apex. This is why Pico della Mirandola's *Oration on the Dignity of Man* (1486) is the necessary counter-text. Pico's God places Adam outside the chain, assigns him no fixed seat and no proper office, and makes his dignity consist precisely in his indeterminacy. Rose Quartz's fascination with humanity—and the series' persistent alignment of the human with the capacity for change—is a Piconian move. Humans are prized not because they are higher on the chain but because they are not on it at all.

1.3 A Dark Herland: Matriarchal Empire and the Refusal of Feminist Essentialism

Homeworld is a civilization without men, without sexual reproduction, and, until Rose Quartz's union with Greg Universe, without heterosexuality. Its subjects present femininely and are referred to with feminine pronouns; its sovereigns are four towering matriarchs. The obvious comparison is Charlotte Perkins Gilman's *Herland* (1915), whose parthenogenetic society organizes itself around collective motherhood and has, in consequence, abolished war, poverty, and domination. Gilman's utopia condenses an assumption that later recurred, in more theoretical dress, in strands of cultural feminism: that a society governed by women, or by values coded as feminine, would tend toward care rather than conquest.

Homeworld is Herland inverted. Its matriarchs "make" their subjects and speak of them in a possessive, quasi-maternal idiom, and the youngest Diamond, Pink, was treated by the others as a child to be indulged and disciplined. Yet this maternal sovereignty is imperial, extractive, and willing to annihilate. The series thereby joins a minority tradition within feminist speculative fiction that refuses the equation of the feminine with the benign: Joanna Russ's *The Female Man* (1975), whose all-female Whileaway is

neither gentle nor innocent, and Sheri S. Tepper's *The Gate to Women's Country* (1988), whose apparently peaceful gynocracy rests on concealed eugenic management. Sara Ruddick's *Maternal Thinking* (1989) is the careful version of the position Homeworld refutes: Ruddick argued not that women are naturally peaceful but that the *practice* of mothering cultivates capacities—preservative love, attention to growth, the training of a child for acceptance by others—that can be turned toward a politics of peace. Homeworld shows what happens when the vocabulary of maternity is retained and the practice abandoned. The Diamonds have the possessiveness of the institution of motherhood that Adrienne Rich distinguished from its experience (Rich 1976), and none of its attentiveness.

The gender of the Gems has a further theoretical edge. Monique Wittig argued that "woman" is a category produced within the heterosexual social contract and has meaning only in relation to "man" (Wittig 1992); on this account a being outside that contract is not, strictly, a woman. The Gems exist wholly outside it, and Sugar's own formulation—that they are nonbinary women—has the structure of a Wittigian paradox: femininity persisting after the contract that defines it has been removed. What remains is femininity as a style of appearance, closer to Judith Butler's account of gender as a stylized repetition of acts that produces the effect of an underlying substance (Butler 1990) than to any doctrine of sexed nature. The decisive consequence for the series' sexual politics is that same-gender love, in a world of feminine beings, cannot itself be the transgression. Homeworld's taboo falls instead on *cross-type* fusion. Rubies may fuse with Rubies for strength; a soldier Ruby may not fuse with an aristocratic Sapphire. In "The Answer," the horror of Blue Diamond's court at Garnet's first appearance is the horror of rank violated, not of gender. The series thereby locates the logic of homophobia where Adrienne Rich's continuum of woman-identified experience (Rich 1980) and the history of anti-miscegenation law both suggest it belongs: in the policing of mixture that maintains a hierarchy of kinds.

That hierarchy is also chromatic. White Diamond, the apex of the order, seeks perfection and controls those around her by draining them of their color, turning them into white extensions of her will; the Gems whom Homeworld hunts as deviant are called, simply, "off colors." Richard Dyer's analysis of whiteness as the power to appear unmarked, universal, and colorless while marking every other position as particular (Dyer 1997) maps onto this iconography without strain. The norm is defined as the absence of color, and deviance is named as color's excess or misplacement. The series does not translate this allegory into a one-to-one racial code, and it would be reductive to do so; its chromatic politics nonetheless names, with unusual clarity for children's television, the operation by which a dominant position claims neutrality.

1.4 Extraction, Thingification, Necropolitics

Homeworld's economy is extraction. Each Kindergarten converts the life of a world into Gems, leaving behind a desiccated landscape, and the empire's continued existence requires new worlds to drain. Rosa Luxemburg argued that capital accumulation depends structurally on a non-capitalist outside that it absorbs and destroys (Luxemburg 1913), and Marx's account of so-called primitive accumulation located the origin of capital in conquest, enclosure, and plunder (Marx 1867, Part VIII). Homeworld's expansion has exactly this structure, and its signs of exhaustion are explicit: the "Era 2" Gems, of whom Peridot is one, were produced with diminished resources and correspondingly diminished capacities, which Peridot initially compensates for with prosthetic limb enhancers. Earth was to have been Pink Diamond's first colony, and its colonization would have ended organic life on the planet.

Aimé Césaire condensed the moral logic of colonialism into a formula: colonization equals thingification (Césaire 1950). The series' most extreme image of that logic is the Cluster, assembled by Homeworld from the shards of Gems shattered in the war and forcibly fused into a planet-sized mass incubating within the Earth, designed to emerge as a geo-weapon that would destroy the world from its core. Earlier, in "Keeping It Together," Pearl and Steven discover the experimental precursors: fragments of different Gems forced into writhing, incoherent bodies. The dead are not permitted to remain dead; they are conscripted as material. The resolution of "Gem Drill" is correspondingly significant. Steven does not destroy the Cluster. He enters its fragmented consciousness and helps its countless pieces form a bubble around themselves, so that the weapon is not defeated but held.

The corruption of the Crystal Gems compounds extraction with terror. At the war's end the Diamonds unleashed a combined blast of their light that left every unprotected Gem on Earth corrupted: deformed into bestial shapes, deprived of speech and memory, neither shattered nor themselves. Achille Mbembe's account of necropolitics, the sovereign power to dictate who may live and who must die and to create "death-worlds" in which populations are kept in the condition of the living dead (Mbembe 2003; 2019), describes this condition precisely. Corruption is not killing but the production of a life that cannot be lived. The Crystal Gems' long practice of capturing and bubbling corrupted Gems, storing them in the Temple until a cure might be found, is accordingly ambiguous in a way the series registers. It is care, but it is also containment; the bubble is a sanctuary and a cell. Frantz Fanon's clinical chapter on colonial war and mental disorder in *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) documents the psychiatric afterlife of colonial violence in both the colonized and the colonizer. *Steven Universe* gives that afterlife a body, and, as Chapter Five argues, eventually gives it to its protagonist.

1.5 Off-Colors: Defect, the Normate, and the Queer Art of Failure

In "Off Colors," Steven and Lars, stranded on Homeworld, are sheltered by Gems who survive in hiding because they fail to conform to type: Rhodonite, an illicit cross-type fusion; Fluorite, a slow-speaking fusion of six; the Rutile Twins, a single Gem with a doubled body; and Padparadscha, a Sapphire whose prophetic sight perceives events only after they have occurred. They are hunted by Homeworld's automated machines because, on Homeworld, a Gem judged defective is marked for shattering, its form of execution. Lars dies defending them and is revived by Steven's tears, returning changed.

Disability studies supplies the vocabulary this episode demands. Rosemarie Garland-Thomson named the "normate," the figure who, by appearing unmarked, defines everyone else as deviant (Garland-Thomson 1997), and later theorized "misfitting" as the relational event in which a body meets a world not built for it (Garland-Thomson 2011). Robert McRuer described compulsory able-bodiedness as a regime that, like compulsory heterosexuality, presents one form of embodiment as the natural default (McRuer 2006). Homeworld's off colors are misfits in exactly this sense, and their pursuit by an apparatus designed to eliminate defect evokes, without allegorical literalism, the eugenic programs of the twentieth century: the compulsory sterilization of disabled people under state laws in the United States, upheld by the Supreme Court in *Buck v. Bell* (1927) and imposed on tens of thousands of people (Lombardo 2008), and the Nazi regime's "euthanasia" program, known as T4, and its successors, under which German physicians and officials murdered an estimated two hundred thousand or more disabled people in institutions (Friedlander 1995). Their refuge in the abandoned underground of Homeworld is a counter-community

formed by shared failure.

Jack Halberstam's *The Queer Art of Failure* (2011), which takes animated film as one of its central archives, argues that failure to meet heteronormative and capitalist standards of success can open alternative ways of being. The series turns this thesis into a recurring structure. Amethyst, dismissed as an under-formed Quartz, becomes the Crystal Gems' most fluid shapeshifter and most irreverent spirit; Peridot, an Era 2 technician who loses her limb enhancers, discovers a new power and a new life; Lars, a human paralyzed by the fear of failing, becomes a starship captain after dying and returning. The series is alert, too, to the risk in such narratives that Eli Clare and other disability theorists have identified, in which the disabled subject is redeemed by acquiring a compensatory power (Clare 2017). Its strongest gestures are those, like the off colors' community, in which deviance is not redeemed by capacity but simply sheltered.

1.6 Petrification: A Provisional Diagnosis

Homeworld's metaphysics can now be stated as four features. First, *assigned essence*: function precedes existence, and a Gem is what it was made for. Second, *irrevocable union*: Homeworld forbids voluntary cross-type fusion while practicing involuntary fusion on the shattered, monopolizing the power to join beings together and denying its subjects the power to join themselves. Third, *erasure of history*: the official account of Pink Diamond's shattering, White Diamond's bleaching of her subjects, and, in the film, a weapon that resets Gems to their manufactured state all treat the past as material to be overwritten. Fourth, *non-reciprocal hierarchy*: care, attention, and service flow upward to the Diamonds, and nothing flows down.

Erich Fromm distinguished between a mode of existence oriented toward *having*, in which persons and things are possessed, accumulated, and controlled, and a mode oriented toward *being*, in which they are related to, used in common, and allowed to change (Fromm 1976). Homeworld is a civilization entirely in the having mode: it owns its Pearls, its colonies, and its subjects' very colors. This dissertation names the condition in which these features converge *petrification*. Petrification is stone without light: essence without becoming, a core so thoroughly identified with its assigned function that the projected self has no room to revise. Every principle of the ethics developed in the following chapters is first visible as the negation of one of petrification's features, and every one of the series' great reversals—fusion, rebellion, inheritance refused, reconciliation, departure—is an act of de-petrification.

CHAPTER TWO

02

Fusion

Consent as Ontogenesis

FUSION IS THE series' central philosophical invention, and its central claim is that consent can bring a person into being and, by its withdrawal, dissolve one. Two or more Gems, moving in synchrony, merge their projected forms into a single, larger being with its own personality, abilities, appearance, and voice; when synchrony fails, or when either party withdraws, the fused person comes apart into its constituents, who return intact. This chapter argues that fusion relocates consent from ethics to ontology, and that in doing so it adjudicates between rival philosophies of union running from Aristophanes to contemporary feminist contract theory.

2.1 Against the Other Half: Aristophanes and the Myth of Lost Wholeness

The West's founding myth of fusion is the speech Plato gives Aristophanes in the *Symposium* (189c–193d). Human beings were once double—round, four-armed, two-faced—until Zeus split them; love is the longing of each half for the other, the desire to recover a lost wholeness. The speech culminates in a hypothetical offer from Hephaestus (192d–e): to weld the lovers together so that they might live as one and, dying, die as one. No lover, Aristophanes says, would refuse.

Steven Universe rejects this myth on three counts. First, its fused partners are not halves but wholes. Ruby and Sapphire are complete persons before they meet, and fusion does not restore a prior unity but creates a new one that neither possessed. Second, fusion is revocable. Hephaestus' offer is a weld, an irreversible union of the kind the series assigns exclusively to its horrors: the forced fusions of shattered Gems and the Cluster. Third, fusion is plural and non-exclusive. Garnet is a romantic fusion, but Opal, Sugilite, Sardonyx, Alexandrite, Smoky Quartz, Stevonnie, and Obsidian are fusions of friendship, collaboration, family, and emergency. The series thus disarticulates intimacy from what Elizabeth Brake named *amatonormativity*, the presumption that romantic coupling is the universal and superior form of

close relation (Brake 2012). Fusion is relation as such, of which romance is one species.

2.2 Relation Before Relata: Spinoza, Buber, Simondon, Barad

The philosophical resources for fusion lie in the minority traditions of Western thought that hold relations to be prior to, or constitutive of, the things related. Spinoza's *Ethics* (1677) contains, in the short treatise on bodies that follows Part II, Proposition 13, a theory of composite individuals that reads as fusion's metaphysical charter. Bodies are distinguished by motion and rest; when several bodies are so constrained that they communicate their motions to one another in a certain fixed ratio, they compose a single body or individual, which retains its nature so long as that ratio is preserved, even if its parts are exchanged. Fusion in the series is achieved through dance, that is, through the establishment of a shared ratio of motion, and it fails when that ratio cannot be held. Gilles Deleuze's reading of Spinoza draws out the ethical consequence: an encounter is good when the relations of two bodies compose into a more powerful whole and bad when one decomposes the other (Deleuze 1981). Garnet is a good encounter rendered visible, a composition whose power of acting exceeds that of either component; Malachite is a bad one, a composition in which each party's power is turned against the other.

Martin Buber's *I and Thou* (1923) opens with the proposition that in the beginning is the relation, and locates the reality of encounter in the "between" that neither party possesses. The I–It relation knows the other as an object of use; the I–Thou relation meets the other as a whole presence. Homeworld relates to its subjects wholly in the mode of I–It. Garnet is the between become a person, and the series' insistence that she is not a thing but an encounter (in "Stronger Than You" she characterizes herself in exactly these terms, as an experience and a conversation rather than an object) is Buber's ontology given a body of light.

Gilbert Simondon's theory of individuation (Simondon 1964/2005; trans. 2020) supplies the most precise account of what fusion produces. Simondon attacked the hylomorphic model, inherited from Aristotle, in which form is imposed on passive matter; his famous counter-example was the brick, which emerges not from the mold's form stamped onto clay but from an energetic process in which clay and mold co-determine a result. The Kindergarten is hylomorphism as industry: form, in the shape of type and function, is stamped onto mineral matter. Fusion is individuation in Simondon's sense, the resolution of a metastable tension between two beings into a new individual that remains charged with unresolved potential. Simondon's "transindividual" names the collective individuation through which individuals become, together, what neither could become alone. That fused Gems have personalities their components cannot predict, and that Ruby and Sapphire are themselves changed by millennia of being Garnet, are consequences of this model and of no other.

Karen Barad's agential realism radicalizes the point. For Barad, relata do not precede their relations; they emerge through "intra-action," and the boundaries between them are enacted by "agential cuts" within phenomena rather than given in advance (Barad 2007). Garnet is a phenomenon in Barad's sense, and unfusion is an agential cut that enacts Ruby and Sapphire as distinct beings, beings who are no longer the Ruby and Sapphire who first fused. Derek Parfit's imagined cases of fusion, in which two persons merge into one with blended psychology, were designed to show that personal identity is not what matters in survival, which consists instead in psychological connectedness and continuity (Parfit 1984). The series grants Parfit's premise and refuses his deflation. Identity is not what matters, but neither is it dissolved into a reductive relation; what matters is the continued consent of the constituents to the relation that

makes the third person. Outside the Western canon the same relational ontology appears in Thich Nhat Hanh's doctrine of interbeing, grounded in the Buddhist teaching of dependent origination, and in the Nguni maxim *umuntu ngumuntu ngabantu*, a person is a person through other persons, which Desmond Tutu made the basis of a theology of reconciliation (Tutu 1999).

2.3 Mature Love and Symbiotic Union: Fromm, Benjamin, and a Typology of Fusion

Erich Fromm's *The Art of Loving* (1956) distinguishes two answers to the human need to overcome separateness. *Symbiotic union* overcomes separateness by abolishing one party's integrity, either passively through submission or actively through domination. *Mature love* is union under the condition of preserving each party's integrity and individuality, and its elements are care, responsibility, respect, and knowledge. bell hooks, defining love as an action rather than a feeling, extended Fromm's account into a feminist ethic in which no relation founded on domination can be loving (hooks 2000). Jessica Benjamin's *The Bonds of Love* (1988) recasts the problem as one of recognition: we need to be recognized by an other we cannot control, and domination is the attempt to secure recognition by controlling the other, which destroys the very independence that would make recognition meaningful. In *Beyond Doer and Done To* (2018) Benjamin names the space that mutual recognition creates the *Third*, and traces its earliest form to the "rhythmic third" of shared attunement between caregiver and infant: a co-created rhythm that belongs to neither partner. The fusion dance is the rhythmic third choreographed.

These frameworks permit a typology of the series' fusions. *Garnet* (Ruby and Sapphire) is mature love in Fromm's precise sense: a union that has lasted millennia while preserving two legible components, fire and ice, impulse and foresight. Her three eyes are the sum of Ruby's two and Sapphire's one, a visual proof that union need not cost either partner anything she brings. *Opal* (Pearl and Amethyst), in "Giant Woman," cannot form while her components are locked in mutual contempt and forms only when they cooperate to save Steven: fusion as the outcome of conflict resolved. *Sugilite* (Garnet and Amethyst), in "Coach Steven," is power as intoxication; she exceeds her mission, refuses to separate, and becomes destructive, while Amethyst's later craving to be Sugilite reveals fusion as an escape from an unloved self. *Sardonyx* (Pearl and Garnet) is theatrical brilliance compromised at its root, since in "Cry for Help" Pearl secretly sabotages a mission so that she and Garnet will have to fuse again. *Alexandrite* (Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearl) is a coalition, colossal and fractious, held together by a common emergency. *Smoky Quartz* (Steven and Amethyst), in "Earthlings," is solidarity between two beings who have each been told they are defective, and is the first fusion founded on mutual self-acceptance. *Malachite* (Lapis Lazuli and Jasper) is symbiotic union in Fromm's sadomasochistic sense: Jasper proposes fusion to win, Lapis accepts in order to imprison her, and in "Chille Tid" Steven sees, beneath the ocean, Lapis binding Jasper in chains of water. The series presents the union, without euphemism, as an abusive relationship, in which a former captive makes her partner captive in turn. When Jasper, in "Alone at Sea," pursues Lapis to resume the fusion, Lapis admits that she had taken out her anger on Jasper and had liked doing so, recognizes the relationship as abusive on both sides, and refuses. The series grants Lapis the double status of victim and perpetrator, refusing what Benjamin calls the complementarity of doer and done-to, in which every relation must sort its parties into one role or the other. Finally, *Bluebird Azurite*, in *Future*'s "Bluebird," is a fusion bound by shared resentment of Steven, an illustration of the instability of unity constituted by a common enemy.

Against all of these stands a non-fusion that the series treats as equally exemplary. Greg Universe, being human, cannot fuse with Rose Quartz. In "We Need to Talk," after watching Rose fuse with Pearl as Rainbow Quartz, Greg tries to learn the dance, fails, and is offered something else: a conversation in which, for the first time, he and Rose speak as equals rather than as worshipper and idol. The episode's title states the alternative, and its importance for the argument of the next sections will be considerable.

2.4 Garnet Against Leviathan: The Political Theory of Fusion

The frontispiece of Thomas Hobbes's *Leviathan* (1651), engraved by Abraham Bosse, depicts the sovereign as a giant whose body is composed of hundreds of small human figures, the subjects who have authorized him. The sovereign is an artificial person produced by covenant; once constituted, he cannot be held to account by his subjects, who retain no right of exit save the inalienable right of self-preservation. The Cluster is the Leviathan as horror: a giant composed of countless fragments of persons who cannot leave it, assembled not by their covenant but by imperial fiat, and destined to destroy the world it inhabits. Rousseau's *Social Contract* (1762, I.6) describes the act of association as producing a moral and collective body with its own unity, its own *moi commun* or common self, its own life and will; and it adds (I.7) that whoever refuses to obey the general will may be compelled, which is to say forced to be free. Fusion is the *moi commun* without the compulsion. A fused Gem who forced one of its constituents to remain would not be a general will but a Malachite.

Garnet is thus a counter-model of political association: an artificial person whose constituents retain, at every moment, the right of exit. She comes apart in "Keystone Motel" when Ruby and Sapphire cannot agree about whether to forgive Pearl's deception, and again after "A Single Pale Rose," when the revelation about Rose Quartz unsettles the ideals on which their union was founded. Each separation is followed not by a restoration of the status quo but by a renegotiated union. Political legitimacy, on this model, is not conferred once by an originating covenant, as in Hobbes, nor presumed through residence, as in Locke's tacit consent, but sustained continuously and revocably by those who compose the body politic.

Carole Pateman's *The Sexual Contract* (1988) explains why this matters for feminism. Pateman argued that the social contract of modern political theory presupposed a sexual contract establishing men's right of access to women, and, more generally, that contracts involving "property in the person"—the employment contract, the marriage contract, and at the limit the slave contract—are not the opposite of subordination but its modern vehicle, since they transfer command over the self. The Pearls embody the slave contract in its pure form, made for service and bound by command. Fusion is the opposite structure: no property in the person is transferred, no party commands the other, and nothing is alienated, because consent is not a transaction completed at the outset but a condition renewed at every instant.

2.5 Consent Made Ontological: Milton, Cavell, Pateman, and the Conditions of Union

In standard moral and legal theory, consent is a normative power: what Heidi Hurd called its "moral magic" lies in its capacity to transform an act that would otherwise be a wrong, such as an entry or a touch, into a permissible one (Hurd 1996; Wertheimer 2003). In *Steven Universe* consent has a stronger power. It does not merely alter the moral status of what persons do; it determines whether a certain person exists. A fused Gem exists only while its components consent to being it; withdrawal dissolves it; deception destabilizes it; coercion deforms it. Consent is, in the series, *ontogenetic*.

> *Consent is, in the series, ontogenetic.*

The early modern source for this principle is John Milton's *The Doctrine and Discipline of Divorce* (1643), which argued against canon law that the chief and noblest end of marriage is "a meet and happy conversation," and that a marriage in which such conversation has become impossible ought to be dissolvable. Stanley Cavell, who took Milton as a guiding authority, argued that the Hollywood comedies of remarriage of the 1930s and 1940s locate the legitimacy of a bond not in law or ceremony but in the couple's willingness to choose one another again, after separation, through conversation (Cavell 1981). The story of Ruby and Sapphire is a comedy of remarriage in Cavell's exact sense. Their first fusion, in "The Answer," is unplanned: Ruby, a guard, leaps to save Sapphire from an attack Sapphire's own future vision had not foreseen, and the two merge in the act. After "A Single Pale Rose," the union founded in Rose Quartz's ideals comes apart; Ruby departs in "The Question" to discover what she wants independently of any script Rose wrote; and she returns to propose. Their wedding in "Reunited" is a second fusion chosen deliberately and with knowledge. The series' most celebrated queer milestone is thus also its most precise statement of a philosophical thesis: a union is legitimate because it is re-chosen, and it can be re-chosen only because it could have been left.

The series' fusion episodes, taken together, yield the conditions of legitimate union with a systematicity that is difficult to attribute to chance. American sex education has popularized, notably through Planned Parenthood, the heuristic that consent must be *freely given, reversible, informed, enthusiastic,* and *specific*. Each condition corresponds to a canonical violation in the series. Malachite violates free giving, since her union is founded on Jasper's ambition and Lapis's revenge and sustained by captivity. The Cluster and the forced fusions violate reversibility, since their fragments cannot leave. Sardonyx in "Cry for Help" violates informed consent, since Garnet consents to a fusion whose occasion Pearl has secretly manufactured. Opal's failure to form in "Giant Woman" exhibits the requirement of enthusiasm, since fusion cannot be achieved by partners who are merely willing. Sugilite violates specificity, since consent given to a mission is extended without renewal to a rampage. What the series has done is to articulate the structure of consent in a register that involves no sexuality at all, which reveals that structure to be a general grammar of relation rather than a special rule of sexual ethics.

Catharine MacKinnon's objection to consent-centered feminism is that, under conditions of structural domination, apparent consent may be indistinguishable from submission (MacKinnon 1989). The series registers this objection in an instructive way. In its ontology, coercion *shows*: Malachite's form is

monstrous, chained, and visibly at war with itself. The world it imagines is utopian precisely in making coercion legible on the surface of the bodies it produces. That utopianism is not naivety but a critical device. By rendering visible what in ordinary life remains hidden, it teaches its audience to look for what structural domination conceals, a lesson the series later applies to the Pearls, whose deformation by command is not visible on their bodies at all.

2.6 Stevonnie: The Hybrid Body, the Gaze, and the Erotic

In "Alone Together," Steven and his friend Connie fuse unexpectedly while dancing on the beach, becoming Stevonnie: a tall, poised, adolescent person, referred to with they/them pronouns, whose body neither of its components recognizes as their own. Garnet, overjoyed, tells them that they are neither two people nor one person but an experience. Stevonnie visits a teenage dance party where an older teenager, Kevin, harasses them with persistent advances and pressure to dance that ignore their evident discomfort; the pressure mounts, and they come apart on the dance floor. The episode thereby stages, in a register accessible to young audiences and without any sexualization of its child characters, the encounter between a body that has just discovered its own capacities and a gaze that would reduce it to an object.

Laura Mulvey's analysis of the cinematic gaze, which divides bearers of the look from objects of "to-be-looked-at-ness" (Mulvey 1975), and Iris Marion Young's phenomenology of feminine comportment, in which the internalized awareness of being looked at produces an "inhibited intentionality" in the body's movement (Young 1980), illuminate the scene's logic. Stevonnie moves with unselfconscious freedom until the objectifying gaze intrudes. Then the person comes apart. In the series' ontology, objectification is not merely an insult to a person but a force that decomposes them. Later Stevonnie episodes extend the figure. The fusion's refusal of a gendered body, and its existence as a single person composed of a girl and a boy, have made Stevonnie a significant figure for nonbinary viewers. The series offers neither a medical nor a taxonomic account of Stevonnie's body; it simply presents a person whose embodiment exceeds the categories of its components.

Audre Lorde's "Uses of the Erotic" (1978) defines the erotic not as sexuality but as a resource of deep feeling and creative power, distinguished from the pornographic, which offers sensation without feeling, and manifest in the sharing of joy, whether physical, emotional, psychic, or intellectual, that forms a bridge between those who share it. Fusion is erotic in exactly this Lordean sense and in no other. That Stevonnie is born of a dance of mutual delight between two friends, and comes apart under an intrusive sexualizing gaze, is the series' clearest articulation of the difference Lorde drew.

2.7 Without Confusion, Without Separation: A Chalcedonian Excursus

The most rigorous premodern attempt to think a single person constituted by the union of two complete natures is the Definition of the Council of Chalcedon (451 CE), which confesses Christ as one person in two natures, united *without confusion, without change, without division, without separation*. The four Greek adverbs (*asynchytōs, atreptōs, adiairetōs, achōristōs*) state, with theological precision, the paradox fusion stages: a union in which the components are neither absorbed into one another nor merely juxtaposed. Garnet's two gems, set in her two palms, remain distinct; her three eyes show that nothing is lost in union; yet she is one person with one voice.

The analogy acquires narrative force in "Change Your Mind," where White Diamond tears Steven's gem from his body in the belief that Pink Diamond lies within it. What emerges is not Pink Diamond but a pink, gem-born Steven, while the human Steven left behind begins to die. The separation of natures produces, in the vocabulary of the fifth-century controversies, something like a Nestorian division into two persons; it is resolved when the two Stevens fuse, restoring a single person in two natures, without separation. No theological intention is claimed here. The point is structural. Fusion recovers, in secular and generalizable form, the oldest Western problem of a person constituted by union without loss, and it extends to every being in its world the possibility that classical theology reserved for one. The same refusal of purity animates Donna Haraway's cyborg, a boundary creature whose politics begin with the rejection of origin stories of wholeness (Haraway 1985), and Gloria Anzaldúa's *mestiza*, whose consciousness learns to hold contradictions without resolving them into either term (Anzaldúa 1987), to which Chapter Six returns.

CHAPTER THREE

03

The Mother's Stone

Rose Quartz, Pink Diamond, and the Ethics of Inheritance

STEVEN EXISTS BECAUSE his mother ceased to. A Gem cannot bear a child with a human without giving up her own form; Rose Quartz's gem became Steven's, and Rose, as a projected person, ended. The series is therefore, from its first episode, a long work of mourning conducted by a child who never met the person he mourns, and its central structural event is the discovery that the person he mourned was not who he, or almost anyone, believed her to be. This chapter reads that discovery as a problem of matrilineal inheritance and argues that its resolution lies not in repudiating the mother nor in redeeming her, but in a birth that is not a continuation.

3.1 The Navel Gem: Matricide, Umbilical Debt, and the Unplumbable Origin

Steven's gem sits in his navel, where his mother's sat. The navel is the scar of the umbilical cord, the bodily memorial of the period in which one lived entirely through another; that the protagonist's core self is lodged at this site is the series' governing symbol. In *The Interpretation of Dreams* (1900), Freud observed that every dream has at least one spot at which it becomes unplumbable, a navel that marks its point of contact with the unknown and at which interpretation must stop. Steven's navel gem is the dream's navel made flesh: the unknown origin of his being, the secret of his mother's identity, is lodged in his own body, unreadable by him.

Luce Irigaray argued that Western culture rests not on the parricide Freud placed at the origin of civilization in *Totem and Taboo* (1913) but on an older and unacknowledged matricide, and that its symbolic order is built on the forgetting of an umbilical debt to the mother (Irigaray 1981; 1987). The series inverts the scene. The mother is not killed; she withdraws, ceding her form so that the son may live, and the resulting order is not one that forgets her but one that cannot stop remembering her, mythologizing her, and paying her debts. In conversation with Irigaray, the biologist Hélène Rouch described the placenta

as an organ formed by the embryo that nonetheless mediates between two organisms, regulating their exchanges so that neither absorbs nor rejects the other (Irigaray 1990). Steven's gem has exactly this placental status. It was his mother's and is now his; it mediates his relation to her without fusing him with her; and the series' climax, examined below, turns on the question of whether the stone carries the mother's identity or only a mediating trace of it.

Julia Kristeva's "Stabat Mater" (1977) argued that the Western cult of the Virgin Mother idealized maternity in a form that silenced the experience of actual mothers. The Crystal Gems' memory of Rose has the structure of such a cult. Her image presides over the Temple; her fountain heals; her tears restore; her lion is a resurrected relic; her room grants wishes; Pearl's devotion is liturgical. Adrienne Rich's distinction between motherhood as institution and as experience (Rich 1976) clarifies what the cult conceals. Rose the institution is the liberator, the nurturer of Earth, the giver of a son. Rose the experience—the person who lived, chose, lied, harmed, and changed—is precisely what the cult cannot hold.

3.2 From Myth to Person: The Revelation of *A Single Pale Rose*

For four seasons the series presents Rose Quartz as the founder of the Crystal Gems, the rebel who defied Homeworld to save Earth and who, at the war's climax, shattered Pink Diamond, the colony's sovereign. Steven inherits this story as an accusation: Homeworld's Gems regard him as Rose, and in "I Am My Mom" he surrenders to them in her name in order to free captured humans, after which he is tried, in "The Trial," for Pink Diamond's murder. The accusation is a debt he assumes without question. Then, in "A Single Pale Rose," the myth falls. Rose Quartz was Pink Diamond. Chafing under the authority of the other Diamonds and drawn to the life of the world she had been given to colonize, she had assumed the form of a Quartz soldier and led a rebellion against her own empire; and, to end the war by removing the reason for it, she staged her own shattering, with Pearl, assuming Rose Quartz's form, appearing to destroy her. The ruse did not end the war. It provoked the Diamonds' grief and fury, and in retaliation they turned their combined light on Earth, corrupting the Gems left there, among them the rebels who had followed her.

The revelation is the series' decisive philosophical event because it converts myth into history. Roland Barthes defined myth as depoliticized speech, a form that transforms history into nature and so removes its contingency from view (Barthes 1957). The myth of Rose had naturalized liberation as the act of a pure heroine against a tyrant external to her. The revelation re-historicizes it: the liberator and the tyrant were one person, the liberation was entangled with deception, and the Diamonds' corruption of her followers was, in part, its consequence. The vocabulary of moral philosophy for this condition is that of dirty hands, the predicament of the political actor who can achieve a good end only by doing wrong (Walzer 1973; Sartre's *Les Mains sales*, 1948), and that of moral luck, in which the moral assessment of an agent depends on outcomes beyond her control (Williams 1981). Whether Pink Diamond's choices were justified depends partly on how things turned out, and they turned out both well and terribly.

The series had prepared the revelation with unusual care. Pink Diamond had once, in a rage, injured her first Pearl, cracking her eye; she had humans abducted from Earth and kept, with their descendants, as specimens in a zoo; she had abandoned a devoted companion, Spinel, in a garden for six thousand years; and as Rose she had disarmed and imprisoned her comrade Bismuth rather than permit a weapon she judged too terrible, a refusal that Bismuth, freed millennia later, would read as hypocrisy once she learned of Pink Diamond's "shattering." The mother's love was real, and so was the sovereign's arbitrariness.

3.3 Splitting and Integration: Klein, Sedgwick, and the Reparative Position

Melanie Klein's account of early psychic life distinguishes two positions (Klein 1935; 1946). In the paranoid-schizoid position the infant splits its objects into the wholly good, which is idealized, and the wholly bad, which is persecutory, protecting the good object by keeping it apart from its failures. In the depressive position the infant comes to recognize that the gratifying and the frustrating mother are one person, and this integration brings guilt, mourning, and the wish to repair the damage that one's own aggression has done to the loved object. The Crystal Gems' world before "A Single Pale Rose" is organized by a split of exactly this kind: Rose the idealized good object and Pink Diamond the persecutory bad one, located safely in an enemy now dead. The revelation forces integration. The beloved mother and the colonial sovereign are one person, and Steven must find a way to love her that does not require her to be good.

Klein also distinguished reparation from its *manic* counterfeit (Klein 1940). Genuine reparation acknowledges loss and the limits of what can be restored; manic reparation is omnipotent and contemptuous, denying dependence and refusing to accept that some damage is permanent. The distinction illuminates the trajectory of the series' last third. Steven's response to the revelation is a campaign of repair: to heal the corrupted Gems, to reconcile with the Diamonds, to restore Spinel, to rehabilitate Homeworld. His literal healing powers make him reparation's instrument. Yet by *Future* his reparative drive has become manic: compulsive, solitary, unable to tolerate either his own limits or other people's autonomy. Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick built her account of reparative reading on Klein's depressive position (Sedgwick 2003), and the series' trajectory refines her model. Reparation is the ethical alternative to paranoia only when it accepts that the reparer, too, is damaged, dependent, and finite.

3.4 Postmemory and the Maternal Archive

Marianne Hirsch coined "postmemory" for the relationship of a second generation to traumatic experiences that preceded its birth but were transmitted so deeply, through stories, images, and behaviors, that they seem to constitute memories in their own right (Hirsch 1997; 2012). Steven's relation to his mother is postmemorial in every respect. He knows her through a videotape recorded before his birth, recovered in "Lion 3: Straight to Video," in which she addresses him as the beginning of a life she could not herself lead; through the armory and relics stored in the pocket dimension of Lion's mane; through Pearl's holographic projections of memory; through the stories of the Gems, which, he will learn, are incomplete; and through dreams in which he sees with others' eyes, as when, in "Steven's Dream," he witnesses Blue Diamond's mourning at Pink Diamond's palanquin. Toni Morrison's term "rememory" in *Beloved* (1987), for memories that persist in places and can be encountered by those who did not live them, describes the series' maternal geography exactly. The palanquin, the zoo, the garden where Spinel waits, and Rose's room are places in which the mother's past remains available to her son.

"Rose's Room" stages the danger of the maternal archive. The room, a space within the Temple that conjures whatever its occupant desires, gives Steven a simulated Beach City whose inhabitants cannot want anything he does not want; the simulation, perfectly compliant, becomes uncanny, and he flees back to the real town and its real, resistant people. Robert Nozick's experience machine, which offers any

experience one could desire and which most people, Nozick argued, would decline because they wish to do things and to be in contact with reality rather than merely to have the experience of it (Nozick 1974), is here given a maternal provenance. The mother's legacy offers the son a world shaped entirely by his wishes, and the son's first ethical act is to refuse it.

3.5 The Colonizer Who Refuses: Memmi, Kenosis, and the Double Descent of Pink Diamond

Albert Memmi's *The Colonizer and the Colonized* (1957) includes a portrait of the "colonizer who refuses": the colonizer of conscience who rejects colonialism but cannot escape the structural position that benefits from it, who is distrusted by the colonized and regarded as a traitor by his own, and whose only coherent options are to live in contradiction or to leave. Pink Diamond is Memmi's figure transposed into myth. Her rebellion did not dissolve her privileges; she retained the sovereign prerogatives of secrecy, unilateral decision, command over her Pearl, and the power to imprison, for millennia, a comrade whose radicalism exceeded her own. Her solutions to the contradiction were, in order, disguise, staged death, and finally the literal cession of her form to her son. Each was a form of exit, and each was undertaken without the consent of those it affected.

Before she was the colonizer who refuses, Pink Diamond was a collector. Her zoo, a sealed habitat aboard a space station in which humans abducted from Earth, and then their descendants, were kept as docile specimens, fed and groomed by Gem keepers and ignorant of where they came from, belongs to a recognizable history: the human zoos of the nineteenth and early twentieth centuries. From 1874 the Hamburg animal dealer Carl Hagenbeck staged "peoples' shows" (*Völkerschauen*) that exhibited Sámi, Nubian, and other peoples alongside animals; the Jardin d'Acclimatation in Paris mounted dozens of "ethnological" exhibitions between 1877 and 1931; the Paris Exposition Universelle of 1889 included a so-called "Negro village"; and the practice persisted at world's fairs as late as Brussels in 1958 (Bancel et al. 2002). The most notorious individual case came earlier. Sarah (Saartjie) Baartman, a Khoikhoi woman from the Cape, was brought to London in 1810 by Hendrik Cesars, in whose household she had worked, and the ship's surgeon Alexander Dunlop, and was exhibited to paying audiences under the colonial label "Hottentot Venus." When abolitionists of the African Institution challenged the exhibition before the Court of King's Bench, her exhibitors produced a contract, and the court accepted that she was there by her own consent. In Paris, where she passed into the hands of an animal showman named Réaux, she was exhibited again and examined by naturalists, Georges Cuvier among them. After her death in December 1815, Cuvier dissected her body, and her skeleton and a cast of her body were displayed in Paris museums until the 1970s. Her remains were returned to South Africa and buried in 2002, after Nelson Mandela's government had requested them (Crais and Scully 2009).

The comparison sharpens three of this dissertation's arguments. First, it qualifies Rose Quartz's love of humanity. Pink Diamond's attachment to Earth's people began as a collector's love, love in what Fromm called the having mode, and the series does not let the later rebel erase the earlier collector. The zoo outlived her: in "Steven's Dream," Blue Diamond takes Greg from Earth as a new specimen for it, and Steven must enter the zoo to bring his father home. Second, the zoo is the dark twin of the bubble. It is holding without revocability, care administered to those who cannot leave, the exact inverse of the held form, and its inhabitants' contentment is not consent. The Baartman case shows that this distinction is a

matter of historical record rather than a fantasy's conceit: a court accepted a contract, produced by the men who profited from her display, as proof that she had agreed to it. It is MacKinnon's objection, examined in Chapter Two, given a date and a courtroom. Third, Baartman's two centuries in museum collections, ended only by repatriation, give the principle of continuity its human-historical form. Repair required neither forgetting nor continued display, but the return of what had been taken and a public acknowledgment of who had taken it.

Pink Diamond's trajectory has a second, theological shape. The early Christian hymn preserved in Philippians 2 describes a being who, though existing in the form of God, emptied himself, taking the form of a servant and being born in human likeness. Pink Diamond's descent is doubly kenotic: from sovereign to soldier, from Diamond to Quartz, and from Gem to human, as her gem becomes her son. The Lurianic Kabbalah's doctrine of *tzimtzum*, in which the infinite contracts itself to make room for a world, and Simone Weil's ethic of "decreation," the withdrawal of the self so that others may exist (Weil 1947), describe the final step with precision. Rose's self-withdrawal is the precondition of Steven's existence. The series is nonetheless clear-eyed about the ambivalence of sovereign self-emptying. A kenosis performed unilaterally remains an act of sovereignty, and its costs fall on those who were not asked. Liberation theology's "preferential option for the poor" (Gutiérrez 1971) asks that the powerful descend toward the oppressed; the series adds that the descent does not absolve the descender of the obligation to tell the truth.

3.6 Inheritance as Task: Nietzsche, Derrida, and the Invisible Ledger

Nietzsche's *On the Genealogy of Morality* (1887) derives the moral concept of guilt (*Schuld*) from the material concept of debt (*Schulden*) and identifies the creditor–debtor relation as the oldest relation between persons, one that extends to the debt a community believes it owes its ancestors. Steven inherits his mother's debts to everyone she wronged: to Bismuth, imprisoned in a bubble for millennia; to Spinel, abandoned; to the Pearl whose eye she cracked; to the corrupted Gems; to the off colors her empire hunted; to Pearl, bound to silence; to the humans of the zoo; and even to the Diamonds, whose grief her deception produced. He pays as if the debt were his own, surrendering in her name, standing trial for her crime, apologizing on her behalf, and healing what she broke. The debt is, in Nietzsche's sense, potentially infinite, which is the formal condition of its becoming guilt.

Jacques Derrida's *Specters of Marx* (1993) offers the corrective. Inheritance, Derrida argued, is never simply given; it is always a task. Because a legacy is internally heterogeneous, the heir must filter, select, and critically reaffirm, inheriting some injunctions and refusing others. Steven's mature relation to his mother is Derridean inheritance. He reaffirms her love of Earth and of life that changes, and he refuses her secrecy, her unilateralism, and her willingness to decide for others what they may know.

The family therapy of Iván Böszörményi-Nagy supplies the clinical form of the same insight (Böszörményi-Nagy and Spark 1973). Families, on this account, keep an intergenerational ledger of merits and debts; children carry "invisible loyalties" to it; the parentified child assumes care for those who should care for him; and those who were wronged may acquire a "destructive entitlement" to wrong others in turn, a description that fits Spinel's revenge and Bismuth's fury. The therapeutic goal Böszörményi-Nagy called *exoneration* is neither forgiveness nor excuse: it is the process by which the heir comes to understand the parent's own wounds, including, in Pink Diamond's case, her infantilization and control by

White Diamond, and is thereby released from destructive loyalty without condoning harm. *Future* is, in large part, the story of Steven's exoneration of his mother, which is also his release from her ledger.

3.7 Natality: Why Steven Is Not His Mother

Hannah Arendt grounded the human capacity for action in *natality*, the fact that each human being is born as a new beginning, so that every birth introduces into the world the possibility of the unprecedented (Arendt 1958). The Diamonds repeatedly misrecognize Steven as Pink. In "Change Your Mind" White Diamond, convinced that Pink Diamond is merely hiding inside him, tears out his gem to release her. What emerges is not Pink Diamond but a second Steven. The scene is the series' most direct refutation of genealogical essentialism. The stone carries continuity but not identity; even the mother's stone, in the son's body, does not transmit the mother. Steven is not Pink Diamond's continuation but a beginning, and his claim to be no one but himself is Arendtian natality asserted against the empire's dynastic logic.

> *The stone carries continuity but not identity.*

Rose's own intention, as the videotape shows, was natality: she wished her son to be himself, not her, and her cession of form was meant to make room for a life she could not live. Her secrets nonetheless conscripted him into a continuation of her life, its debts, and its war. The tension between these two legacies, the gift of a beginning and the burden of a ledger, drives the remainder of the series, and its resolution in *Future* is the son's assumption of the gift and his release from the burden.

3.8 The Feminist Son: Masculinity Without Separation

Nancy Chodorow argued that, in societies where women do the primary work of parenting, boys establish masculine identity by differentiating themselves from the mother, defining masculinity negatively as not-mother and at the cost of emotional constriction (Chodorow 1978). Steven is raised by three Gem guardians and an absent mother whose stone he carries; his masculinity is founded not on separation but on identification, and its markers are those the patriarchal script assigns to the feminine: tears, song, tenderness, the color pink, a weapon that protects rather than wounds. Raewyn Connell's account of hegemonic masculinity as the culturally dominant configuration of male practice, sustained by the subordination of alternatives (Connell 1995), helps situate the series' men. Greg is a gentle, emotionally available, conflict-avoidant father who lives in a van; Lars is a boy whose cruelty masks terror of failure; Kevin is the series' figure of predatory entitlement. Steven belongs to none of these.

bell hooks argued that patriarchy's first act of violence against boys is not against women but against the boys themselves, who are taught to kill off their own emotional lives, retaining only anger (hooks 2004). Steven is spared that mutilation. *Future* reveals that he has suffered a different one. The feminist son is not permitted even anger. He must be endlessly gentle, endlessly available, endlessly good, and his rage, when it comes, arrives as a monstrous transformation of his body. In "Mr. Universe" it is directed, at last, at his father, for a childhood without school, spent in a van and handed over to immortal guardians who needed him to be their savior. The series thereby completes hooks's analysis: the patriarchal script

and its inversion share a structure, since both require the boy to suppress some part of himself in order to be loved.

CHAPTER FOUR

04

Shield and Sword

Nonviolence, Decolonization, and the Problem of the Diamonds

THE SERIES' POLITICS turn on a single substitution. Rose Quartz fought with a sword; her son fights, when he must, with a shield. This chapter examines what the substitution commits the series to, tests it against the strongest objections from the tradition of anticolonial thought, and concludes that the series' reconciliation with the Diamonds succeeds as an ethics of interpersonal repair while falling short, by the series' own standards, as a politics of decolonization.

4.1 The Shield as Ethical Instrument

Rose bequeathed two weapons: a sword, which passes to Connie, and a shield, which manifests from Steven's gem. Steven's characteristic powers—the shield, the protective bubble, healing saliva and tears, empathic entry into other minds—are all technologies of protection, containment, and repair. Even his offensive acts tend to take the form of holding: he does not destroy the Cluster but helps it bubble itself; he does not shatter corrupted Gems but contains them until they can be healed. Ursula K. Le Guin's "The Carrier Bag Theory of Fiction" (1986) argued that the first cultural device was more probably a container than a weapon, and that the heroic narrative of the spear has occluded the more fundamental story of gathering, holding, and carrying home. Steven's arsenal is a carrier bag. The narrative consequence, treated in Chapter Six, is a series whose plots are organized less around victories than around the gathering of beings into relation.

The ethical lineage of the shield is the modern tradition of principled nonviolence. Gandhi's *satyagraha*, the force of truth, sought not to defeat the opponent but to convert him, and treated the willingness to absorb suffering without inflicting it as a means of moral persuasion (Gandhi 1909). Martin Luther King Jr. took the end of nonviolent struggle to be reconciliation and the creation of a "beloved community" in which former adversaries live together (King 1958). Steven's method is recognizably theirs:

he converts adversaries—Peridot, Lapis Lazuli, Bismuth, eventually the Diamonds and Spinel—through conversation, exposure to his own vulnerability, and an insistence that they are capable of becoming otherwise.

Judith Butler's *The Force of Nonviolence* (2020) clarifies what distinguishes this from passivity. Nonviolence, Butler argues, is not the absence of force but a forceful practice that operates within a field of violence in which the practitioner is already implicated, and its ethical core is the assertion of the equal grievability of all lives, including the lives of those designated as enemies. The series insists on both points. Steven's nonviolence is chosen against an available capacity for annihilation: in *Future*'s "Fragments" he shatters Jasper in a fury and then, horrified, heals her. And the series' moral imagination extends grievability universally. The Diamonds' grief for Pink is shown as real; the corrupted Gems are mourned as persons rather than destroyed as monsters; even the Cluster is treated as a multitude of the dead who deserve to be held.

4.2 Bismuth's Breaking Point and the Fanonian Objection

The series gives the case against nonviolence to Bismuth, the smith who forged the Crystal Gems' weapons. She designed the Breaking Point, a weapon capable of shattering a Diamond, and proposed using it to end the war; Rose refused and imprisoned her in a bubble, where she remained for millennia. Released in "Bismuth," she learns of Pink Diamond's "shattering" and concludes that Rose was a hypocrite who forbade others the act she reserved for herself. She urges Steven to finish the war by destroying its authors. Steven refuses, and when she turns on him he poofs and bubbles her, repeating his mother's act in the very episode that condemns it.

Bismuth's position is Frantz Fanon's. *The Wretched of the Earth* (1961) opens with the claim that decolonization is always a violent phenomenon, that colonialism is violence in its natural state and will yield only to greater violence, and that the violence of the colonized is a cleansing force that frees them from despair and inaction. The series does not caricature this position. Bismuth is not a villain; her grievances are just, her analysis of Rose's hypocrisy is correct, and her comrades receive her back with love. The narrative overrides her argument rather than refuting it, and the override depends on a contingency the Fanonian would note at once: the Diamonds turn out to be persuadable. A politics of conversion requires a convertible opponent, and the series' resolution can seem to purchase its pacifism by stipulating that tyrants are, at bottom, wounded and reachable.

Two further resources sharpen the debate. Audre Lorde's dictum that the master's tools will never dismantle the master's house (Lorde 1979) was formulated about the reproduction of exclusion within feminist practice, not about armed struggle; but the Breaking Point is, quite literally, the master's tool. Shattering is Homeworld's own method, and a rebellion that adopts it risks reproducing the logic of disposability it opposes. Against this, King's "Letter from Birmingham Jail" (1963) reserved its sharpest criticism not for segregationists but for moderates who preferred an absence of tension to the presence of justice and counseled the oppressed to wait. Bismuth is the series' voice of that impatience, and a faithful reading must hold both Lorde's warning and King's rebuke in view.

Walter Benjamin's "Critique of Violence" (1921) supplies a third and more exacting frame. Benjamin distinguished two forms of what he called mythic violence, both bound to law: *law-making* violence, which founds a legal order, and *law-preserving* violence, which maintains it, as armies and police do. Against both

he set a "divine" violence that destroys law rather than founding it, and he found its political image in the proletarian general strike, an idea he took from Georges Sorel (Sorel 1908): a strike that aims not to seize the state but to depose it. He also identified a sphere of human agreement that violence cannot reach at all, the sphere of conversation and understanding, in which differences are settled by what he called pure means, without coercion (Benjamin 1921).

Benjamin's categories fit the Bismuth episode with uncomfortable precision. Bismuth presents the Breaking Point as divine violence in Benjamin's sense, a justice that would end the Diamonds' order rather than found another. Structurally, however, it is law-making violence: by shattering the Diamonds it would found a new order on the very act by which the old one ruled, making the rebels the new holders of the power to shatter. Rose's response, imprisoning Bismuth for millennia to stop her, is law-preserving violence exercised within the revolution itself: the rebellion enforcing by force its own rule against shattering, a rule its leader would later appear to break. Steven's method belongs to the sphere Benjamin judged inaccessible to violence, and it recalls the series' account of Garnet as a conversation. The finale, however, fits none of Benjamin's categories. When the Diamonds change their minds, the caste order they imposed is abolished, but its authors are not deposed; the law is changed by the lawgivers themselves, and the source of law survives the change. Benjamin thus sharpens the critique developed in section 4.5. The series refuses law-making violence, and it also forgoes the deposition Benjamin hoped the general strike would bring, settling instead for the sovereign's conversion.

The essay's later reception bears on how the series should be judged. Jacques Derrida warned that Benjamin's notion of a divine violence, lethal yet bloodless, comes dangerously close to sanctioning annihilation in the name of justice (Derrida 1990); Judith Butler read the same essay as a critique of legal coercion that opens onto a commitment to nonviolence (Butler 2006). The series stages that dispute in its two revolutionaries. Bismuth's Breaking Point is divine violence as Derrida feared it; Steven's conversion of the Diamonds is Benjamin read as Butler hoped. What the series cannot imagine is the deposition of a sovereign without either shattering her or securing her consent.

4.3 Freire on Homeworld: Liberating the Oppressor

Paulo Freire's *Pedagogy of the Oppressed* (1968) supplies the theory that best explains the series' strategy. Oppression, Freire argued, dehumanizes oppressor and oppressed alike, so that the historical task of the oppressed is to liberate both themselves and their oppressors; and the oppressed, having internalized the image of the oppressor, experience a "fear of freedom" and tend, when they acquire power, to reproduce the hierarchy that formed them. The series is a gallery of Freirean figures. Peridot initially reveres the Diamonds as the source of all value; Pearl continues to seek orders long after the order that issued them has fallen; Jasper cannot imagine herself outside rank; and Holly Blue Agate, a functionary in Pink Diamond's zoo, is cruel to the Gems beneath her precisely because she is herself subordinate.

Freire opposed the "banking" concept of education, in which knowledge is deposited by teachers into passive students, to a dialogical, problem-posing pedagogy in which teacher and student investigate their world together. Steven's method, at its best, is dialogical; his conversations with Peridot and Lapis, and finally with the Diamonds, proceed by questions rather than deposits. *Future* tests this method institutionally. Little Homeschool, the academy Steven founds to help Homeworld's Gems learn to live on Earth, gradually reveals his own drift toward the banking model and toward what Freire called "false

generosity," the charity that perpetuates the dependence it relieves. In "Guidance," Steven is unsettled when Gems trained in his school make choices about their lives without consulting him. Freire's warning that revolutionary leaders who do not trust the people will reproduce domination in a new form is staged, gently but unmistakably, in the conduct of the protagonist himself.

4.4 Forgiveness, Promise, and the Limits of the Forgivable

Hannah Arendt identified two faculties that redeem human action from its characteristic predicaments (Arendt 1958, §§33–34). Forgiveness remedies the *irreversibility* of action, releasing agents from the consequences of what they have done so that they can begin again; promising remedies its *unpredictability*, binding an uncertain future through mutual commitment. The series dramatizes both with unusual exactness. Sapphire's future vision, which in "The Answer" fails to foresee Ruby's intervention and their fusion, embodies the unpredictability of action: love is precisely what prophecy cannot see, which is to say, in Arendt's terms, the infinitely improbable that action brings into the world. Ruby and Sapphire's vows in "Reunited" are the series' great promise. Steven's treatment of his enemies is its great forgiveness.

Arendt also marked forgiveness's limit: human beings are unable to forgive what they cannot punish, and unable to punish what has proved unforgivable, the domain she associated with radical evil. Vladimir Jankélévitch argued that crimes against humanity are imprescriptible and therefore beyond forgiveness (Jankélévitch 1971); Jacques Derrida, inverting the claim, held that forgiveness worthy of the name forgives only the unforgivable, and that conditional forgiveness, granted in exchange for repentance, is not forgiveness but economy (Derrida 2001). The Diamonds' crimes—draining whole worlds of life to manufacture their subjects, corrupting the Gems left on Earth at the war's end, and conscripting the shards of the war dead into a weapon designed to destroy all life on the planet—belong to the category Arendt and Jankélévitch placed beyond forgiveness. The series' answer is closer to the restorative model of Desmond Tutu's Truth and Reconciliation Commission, in which amnesty was conditioned on full disclosure and in which reconciliation was understood, through the theology of *ubuntu*, as the restoration of a community rather than the cancellation of a debt (Tutu 1999). The Diamonds are not simply forgiven. They are confronted with what they did, made to participate in its repair, and changed.

The criminological literature of restorative justice supplies a further frame. Howard Zehr redefined crime as harm to people and relationships, to be addressed by repair and accountability rather than by punishment alone (Zehr 1990), and Nils Christie argued that the state "steals" conflicts from the parties to whom they belong (Christie 1977). The series returns its central conflict to its parties. The Diamonds' corruption of the Crystal Gems is undone not by an external authority but by the Diamonds themselves, whose combined powers, together with Steven's, are required to heal what they did; the authors of the harm are made the agents of its repair.

4.5 The Diamond Problem: Reconciliation Without Redistribution?

The paranoid objection must now be stated at full strength. The series' finale redeems three imperial sovereigns who drained whole worlds of life to manufacture their subjects, who together corrupted the Gems left on Earth at the war's end, all but the few Rose Quartz shielded, and under whose rule a weapon was planted in Earth's core to destroy every living thing on the planet. Transposed into human terms, these are crimes against humanity, and the last would have exterminated humanity itself. The series redeems their authors in the idiom of family dysfunction: White Diamond's perfectionism, Blue Diamond's grief, Yellow Diamond's repression. Political crimes are recast as psychological wounds. The sovereigns remain enthroned. The protagonist, himself a child, performs the emotional labor of their rehabilitation, and the formerly colonized are asked to accept their former rulers as kin. On this reading the series exemplifies what Nancy Fraser criticized as the displacement of redistribution by recognition, in which struggles over the structure of power are converted into struggles over esteem (Fraser 1995; Fraser and Honneth 2003).

The objection acquires its sharpest form through Glen Coulthard's *Red Skin, White Masks* (2014). Drawing on Fanon, Coulthard argued that the liberal politics of recognition (Taylor 1992) reproduces colonial power, because it locates the freedom of the colonized in the recognition granted by the colonizer, who retains the power to define its terms. The series' climax has exactly this structure: Earth's freedom and the healing of its Gems depend on the Diamonds' coming to recognize that they were wrong. Eve Tuck and K. Wayne Yang's warning that decolonization is not a metaphor (Tuck and Yang 2012), and that its metaphorization permits "moves to innocence" that leave the material structure of settlement intact, applies with particular force to Little Homeworld, a settlement of former imperial subjects on Earth, which the series presents with warmth and without asking the question of land.

Three considerations temper, without dissolving, the objection. First, the series does depict structural change: the abolition of Homeworld's caste order in what is called Era 3, the freedom of Gems to choose their occupations and their fusions, and the healing of the corrupted. Second, in an absolute monarchy the sovereign's psyche is itself a political institution, and the series' focus on the Diamonds' psychology is, in that context, a focus on the state. Third, the narrative itself registers a residue. The Diamonds' love for Steven remains possessive; their authority remains unconstrained by those they rule; and *Future* leaves their sovereignty structurally intact.

The resolution proposed here is an immanent critique. Chapter Two established that, in the series' own ontology, a union is legitimate only while those who compose it can withdraw. A Homeworld in which the Diamonds' authority cannot be revoked by their subjects violates that principle, however reformed its rulers' hearts. By the standard of the held form, the series' reconciliation succeeds as an ethics of interpersonal repair and partially as institutional reform, but it does not complete the decolonization its own premises demand, because it changes the minds of the sovereigns without making their sovereignty revocable. The series thus supplies the very criterion by which its political settlement falls short, and this is a mark of its seriousness rather than a refutation of it.

It changes the minds of the sovereigns without making their sovereignty revocable.

4.6 Spinel and the Rejuvenator: Abandonment, Erasure, Re-enactment

Steven Universe: The Movie compresses the series' ethics of inheritance into a single figure. Spinel was Pink Diamond's playmate, told to wait in a garden while Pink left for her new colony and then forgotten for six thousand years. Learning that Pink is gone and that her son lives, she comes to Earth armed with an injector to poison the planet and with the Rejuvenator, a weapon that resets Gems to their manufactured state, erasing memory and personality. Her design changes with her history. The rounded, rubber-limbed, perpetually grinning playmate, whose design evokes the rubber-hose style of early American cartoons, has remade herself into an angular figure of menace; abandonment has re-formed her. In John Bowlby's terms, she is a child who never found a secure base (Bowlby 1988); in Catherine Malabou's, examined in Chapter Five, her change of form is destructive plasticity, the production of a new identity by trauma; and in Böszörményi-Nagy's, her vengeance is destructive entitlement, the claim to harm others that unacknowledged injury confers.

The Rejuvenator is the series' purest figure of erasure, the violation of the principle of continuity. Its victims do not die; they are restored to a factory condition in which the histories that made them who they are have been deleted. The film's resolution is correspondingly instructive. The reset Crystal Gems are restored not by a technical reversal but by re-enactment: Ruby and Sapphire, returned to their original programming, meet again and fall in love again, and Garnet re-forms. The recovery nonetheless depends on something persisting in the stone, since memory returns; identity, on the series' account, is neither stored data alone nor relation alone, but a durable remainder reactivated through relation. Spinel's own resolution has been, with reason, among the most debated in the corpus: she departs with the Diamonds, whose sister abandoned her, to join their household. The film presents this as her choice of attachment and as evidence of the Diamonds' transformation. Structurally it repeats the Diamond problem in miniature, and it is best read as an honest instance of that problem rather than as its solution.

CHAPTER FIVE

05

Here Comes a Thought

Affect, Trauma, and the Politics of Care

STEVEN UNIVERSE IS, among other things, a treatise on the emotions, and its account of them is political throughout. Its characters' feelings are shaped by the regimes that made them, transmitted by the sovereigns who rule them, and inscribed on bodies that can be deformed by what they have endured. This chapter traces that account from the series' theory of emotional integration through its portraits of grief, shame, and captivity to *Steven Universe Future*, which turns the series' psychology against its own protagonist.

5.1 Wise Mind: Garnet as Dialectical Synthesis

In "Mindful Education," Steven and Connie, fused as Stevonnie for sword training, are undone by guilt each cannot stop rehearsing. Garnet's response, the song "Here Comes a Thought," teaches them to observe thoughts arriving and departing without being carried away by them, and to understand that they are not identical to what passes through their minds. The practice descends from the Buddhist cultivation of *sati*, transmitted to Western audiences by Thich Nhat Hanh's *The Miracle of Mindfulness* (1975) and institutionalized in Jon Kabat-Zinn's mindfulness-based stress reduction (Kabat-Zinn 1990).

The deeper correspondence is with Marsha Linehan's dialectical behavior therapy, which teaches the cultivation of "wise mind," the integration of "emotion mind" and "reasonable mind" into a state that includes both and is reducible to neither (Linehan 1993). Garnet is wise mind given a body: Ruby, hot and impulsive, and Sapphire, cool and prescient, integrated in a person whose characteristic affect is calm without coldness. The contrast with the classical model is instructive. Plato's charioteer in the *Phaedrus* (246a–254e) achieves order by mastering the unruly horse; Garnet achieves it by integrating rather than subordinating. Feminist philosophy's critique of the reason–emotion hierarchy, from Genevieve Lloyd's history of the gendering of reason (Lloyd 1984) to Alison Jaggar's defense of the epistemic value of emotion (Jaggar 1989), finds in Garnet an image of a reason that does not rule feeling but converses with it. When

that conversation breaks down, as in "Keystone Motel," Ruby's fury heats one half of a motel room while Sapphire's withdrawal freezes the other, and Steven, caught between them like a child between quarreling parents, experiences the divided self as a divided climate.

5.2 Pearl: Melancholia, Disenfranchised Grief, and the Ethics of Devotion

Pearl loved Rose Quartz, and Rose loved Greg. Pearl's grief, sung in "It's Over, Isn't It" in the musical episode "Mr. Greg," is the series' most sustained portrait of a loss that cannot complete itself. Freud distinguished mourning, in which the libido is gradually withdrawn from a lost object, from melancholia, in which the lost object is incorporated into the ego and the self-reproaches that would have been directed at the object are directed at the self instead (Freud 1917). Pearl's perfectionism, her self-reproach, and her inability to separate her identity from Rose's are melancholic in this precise sense. Judith Butler extended Freud's account to argue that attachments a culture forbids its subjects to grieve, paradigmatically same-sex attachments, are preserved through melancholic incorporation (Butler 1997). Kenneth Doka's concept of disenfranchised grief, the grief that is not openly acknowledged, socially sanctioned, or publicly mourned, names Pearl's social position exactly (Doka 1989). She was not Rose's partner; Greg was. The person whose loss defines her life was never, in the public sense, hers to lose.

Pearl's devotion has an ethical shape as well as a psychological one. In "Sworn to the Sword" she trains Connie as a knight whose highest aim is to die for Steven, as Pearl was prepared to die for Rose; Steven, appalled, refuses to be the cause for which his friend is willing to perish. Beauvoir's chapter on "The Woman in Love" in *The Second Sex* (1949) describes a love that makes a god of the beloved and seeks self-realization through self-abdication, and contrasts it with an authentic love in which two freedoms recognize one another. Pearl is Beauvoir's woman in love, and the series' answer to her is Beauvoir's. The comparison with Ikuhara's *Revolutionary Girl Utena* is unavoidable here: Anthy, the "Rose Bride" owned by whoever wins the duel, is the servant whose liberation requires the refusal of the knightly and princely roles that have defined her. Pearl, a servant who made herself a knight, must in turn unlearn knighthood. The series marks the beginning of that unlearning with tenderness: in "Last One Out of Beach City," Pearl, for the first time, pursues a stranger, though the stranger's pink hair suggests that even desire's new beginnings carry the color of the old.

5.3 Amethyst: Shame and the Kindergarten Origin

Amethyst emerged alone from the Prime Kindergarten after the war, smaller than a standard Quartz and late; she was raised by the Gems who had fought to prevent the very Kindergarten that made her. In "On the Run" she confesses the shame of that origin. Her existence is the product of the violation of the world she loves. Silvan Tomkins defined shame as the affect that arises when interest or enjoyment is incompletely interrupted (Tomkins 1963), and Eve Kosofsky Sedgwick and Adam Frank argued that shame is peculiarly identity-constituting, since it turns the subject toward the question of what it is (Sedgwick and Frank 1995; Sedgwick 2003). Amethyst's response to shame is theatrical: she is the series' great shapeshifter and clown, and in "Tiger Millionaire" she wrestles under the persona of the Purple Puma. Sedgwick's account of the bond between shame and queer performativity, and Susan Sontag's earlier description of camp as a sensibility of exaggeration and artifice (Sontag 1964), illuminate this strategy. Amethyst performs what she is ashamed of until performance becomes a form of freedom.

The series' answer to her shame is twofold. In "Earthlings" she fuses with Steven as Smoky Quartz, a fusion founded on shared self-acceptance between two beings told they are inadequate; and in "That Will Be All" she meets, in Pink Diamond's zoo, the Amethysts who emerged alongside her and greet her as one of their own by her Kindergarten designation. Shame of origin is answered not by repudiating the origin but by finding kin within it. The figure resonates with a recurrent problem in postcolonial and Chicana feminist writing, the problem of being born from the violation one opposes, which Anzaldúa approached through the *mestiza* who refuses to disown any part of a conflicted inheritance (Anzaldúa 1987).

5.4 Lapis Lazuli: Captivity, Flight, and Recovery

Lapis Lazuli is the series' portrait of captivity and its sequelae. Trapped in a mirror for millennia, she emerges in "Mirror Gem" and "Ocean Gem" desperate to return home, drains the ocean to build a tower toward the sky, and is healed by Steven, who repairs her cracked gem. Returned to Earth as a prisoner of Homeworld, she fuses with Jasper as Malachite in order to imprison her, and so turns her own captivity into the captivity of another. After Malachite's separation she lives in a barn with Peridot, struggling to inhabit a world she has resided in but never chosen; when Homeworld threatens again, in "Raising the Barn," she flees with the barn into space rather than fight another war.

Judith Herman's *Trauma and Recovery* (1992) argued that prolonged captivity produces a complex syndrome distinct from the effects of a single traumatic event, and that recovery proceeds through three stages: establishing safety, remembrance and mourning, and reconnection. Lapis's arc follows Herman's stages with striking fidelity, and the series refuses to moralize the first of them. Her flight is not cowardice but the survivor's insistence on safety, and the narrative honors it. Herman also argued that the study of trauma has advanced only when allied with political movements, and that the trauma of war and the trauma of domestic and sexual captivity are continuous. Lapis, injured first by war and then by a relationship in which she was both captive and captor, embodies that continuity.

5.5 Sovereign Affect: The Diamonds and the Transmission of Feeling

The Diamonds rule partly by imposing feeling. Blue Diamond's grief radiates as an aura that compels everyone around her to weep; White Diamond's dominion drains her subjects of color and makes them act and speak as extensions of her will. Teresa Brennan's *The Transmission of Affect* (2004) challenged the assumption that emotions are contained within individuals, arguing that affects pass between bodies and atmospheres. Sara Ahmed's account of affective economies, in which emotions circulate and accumulate value as they attach to objects and bodies (Ahmed 2004), extends the point to politics. Homeworld is an affective economy administered from above: its sovereigns monopolize the right to feel and distribute their feelings to their subjects as obligations.

Arlie Russell Hochschild's study of emotional labor showed how employers impose "feeling rules" that require workers to manage their own emotions as part of their work (Hochschild 1983). Homeworld's feeling rules are total, and the liberation the series imagines is in part an affective liberation: the right to one's own grief, anger, and joy. The theme returns, transformed, in *Future*, where the protagonist who freed others from imposed feeling turns out to be governed by feeling rules of his own.

5.6 *Steven Universe Future* as Trauma Narrative

Future begins after victory. The war is over, Homeworld reformed, the corrupted healed, and Steven, now sixteen, has nothing left to fight. His symptoms emerge in peace: hypervigilance, an inability to rest, powers that activate involuntarily, and a body that glows pink under stress. In "Growing Pains," Connie's mother, a physician, examines him, connects his symptoms to a childhood of crises, and gently recommends therapy. In "Prickly Pair," a cactus he nurtures absorbs his unspoken resentments, repeats them, and turns violent. In "Mr. Universe" his anger at his father erupts; in "Fragments" he shatters Jasper; in "Everything's Fine" he insists, against all evidence, that he is well. In "I Am My Monster" he becomes a colossal pink creature resembling the corrupted Gems he once healed, and is restored only when the people who love him surround and hold him and his own tears heal him. In "The Future," having begun therapy, he leaves Beach City.

Cathy Caruth defined trauma by its belatedness: an event not fully experienced when it occurred returns later, insistently, as if for the first time (Caruth 1996). *Future*'s postwar setting is belatedness made structural, since the war's trauma arrives only when the war is over. Bessel van der Kolk's argument that traumatic experience is stored and expressed somatically (van der Kolk 2014) is literalized in Steven's luminous, uncontrollable body. Catherine Malabou's concept of *destructive plasticity* gives the deepest account of what threatens him. Malabou distinguished plasticity, the capacity both to receive and to give form, and also to annihilate it, from mere flexibility, the passive adaptability prized by contemporary capitalism; and she argued that trauma and brain injury can produce "new wounded" persons whose identities are not damaged versions of the old but new forms, discontinuous with the past and often emotionally indifferent to it (Malabou 2007; 2009). Corruption is destructive plasticity: the Gem survives, but as a form unconnected to who she was. Steven's monstrous transformation is the moment at which destructive plasticity threatens the protagonist himself, and its reversal, through being held, is the series' answer to it.

The psychoanalytic and feminist literature on compliance completes the picture. Winnicott described a "false self" that develops when a child must adapt to the needs of its environment, protecting a hidden true self behind compliance (Winnicott 1960). Alice Miller described the "gifted child" whose sensitivity to parental need becomes the organizing principle of a life (Miller 1979). Sara Ahmed analyzed the "happiness duty" by which certain subjects are required to be happy so that others may be comfortable (Ahmed 2010), and Lauren Berlant defined "cruel optimism" as an attachment to an object that impedes the flourishing it promises (Berlant 2011). Steven's cheerfulness is a false self in Winnicott's sense; he is Miller's gifted child, a happy object for the Gems' grief, and cruelly attached to the role of savior that is destroying him.

5.7 The Unheld Holder: Care Ethics and the Doulia Principle

The ethics of care, beginning with Carol Gilligan's *In a Different Voice* (1982) and Nel Noddings's *Caring* (1984), held that moral life is constituted by relations of responsiveness and that the care relation is completed only when the one cared for receives and responds. Joan Tronto distinguished four phases of care—caring about, taking care of, care-giving, and care-receiving—and later added a fifth, "caring with," in which care becomes a shared democratic practice (Tronto 1993; 2013). Eva Feder Kittay's *Love's Labor* (1999) introduced the principle she named *doulia*, after the *doula* who cares for the new mother: as we have been cared for, so we must ensure that those who care for others are themselves cared for. Dependency workers, Kittay argued, are made vulnerable by their work and are owed support in proportion to it.

Steven is a dependency worker who has never been the beneficiary of doulia. Since childhood he has cared for Pearl's grief, Amethyst's shame, Garnet's crises, Lapis's fear, the Diamonds' rehabilitation, and Little Homeworld's integration, and the series' early structure, in which every episode resolves through his attentiveness, made his care the engine of its plots. Emmanuel Levinas described the ethical subject as infinitely and asymmetrically responsible for the other, to the point of being, in his later work, a "hostage" substituted for the other (Levinas 1961; 1974). Steven, who literally surrenders himself as a hostage in his mother's name, is the Levinasian subject made a child, and *Future* reveals the cost of that ethic when no one shares it. The series' correction is the care ethicist's: responsibility must circulate, and holding must be reciprocal. Audre Lorde's insistence, written during her illness, that caring for oneself is not self-indulgence but self-preservation, and as such a political act (Lorde 1988), is the principle Steven learns last. When, in "I Am My Monster," his friends, family, and former enemies hold him, the holder is held for the first time, and only then can his own healing begin.

Responsibility must circulate, and holding must be reciprocal.

5.8 Therapy and Its Discontents

The series' explicit endorsement of therapy is, in the context of American children's television, a significant act of destigmatization, and it has been widely received as such. It must also be weighed against the critique of therapeutic culture. Philip Rieff warned of a "triumph of the therapeutic" in which psychological well-being replaces shared moral and religious frameworks (Rieff 1966); Christopher Lasch diagnosed a culture of narcissism (Lasch 1979); and Eva Illouz showed how therapeutic discourse converts social suffering into individual pathology and narratives of self-help (Illouz 2008). The danger is plain. Steven's trauma is political in origin. It is the product of a colonial war, of an empire, and of the choices of the adults around him: the Crystal Gems, who trained a child for combat and took him into their war, and his father, who left that upbringing to them. A therapeutic resolution risks individualizing what was collective.

The series answers the danger in three ways. It locates Steven's trauma explicitly in the war and in the conduct of the adults around him, including his father, who acknowledges his failures. It pairs therapy with structural change, since the reformation of Homeworld and the founding of Little Homeworld precede and accompany Steven's recovery. And it never shows the therapy itself. The withholding preserves the patient's privacy and refuses to make the clinic a scene of cure, keeping therapy a horizon rather than a solution. The series' last word on Steven's suffering is not that it has been fixed but that it is now shared, which is the difference between a curative and a caring account of recovery and the point at which this chapter's argument passes into the political theory of the next.

CHAPTER SIX

06

The Carrier Bag of Beach City

Kinship, the Ordinary, and the Plural Polis

THE SERIES' METAPHYSICS is cosmic, but its ethics is local. Its decisive scenes occur in a donut shop, a pizzeria, a car wash, a barn, a beach house, and a boardwalk arcade in the off-season. This chapter argues that the series' attention to the ordinary is not a pause in its philosophy but the place where its philosophy is tested, and that its forms of kinship, settlement, song, and production extend the ethics of the held form from persons to communities.

6.1 Filler as Form: Le Guin's Carrier Bag and Cavell's Ordinary

The series' early seasons, built from eleven-minute episodes in which Steven helps a fry-stand owner, befriends a pizzeria family, or tags along on a donut-shop clerk's errands, were frequently dismissed by impatient viewers as "filler" standing between the episodes that advanced its mythology. The charge mistakes the series' form. Le Guin's carrier bag theory proposed that the novel is fundamentally a bag rather than a spear, a container of many things in relation rather than the trajectory of a single heroic act (Le Guin 1986). The series is constructed on this principle. Its "filler" episodes gather the town into the narrative one relation at a time, so that when the cosmic plot arrives, Beach City is not a backdrop to be saved but a web of particular people whose claims on Steven, and on the audience, have already been established.

Stanley Cavell, following Wittgenstein's project of leading words back from their metaphysical to their everyday use, made the ordinary the place where philosophical skepticism is lived and overcome (Cavell 1979). Henri Lefebvre treated everyday life as a site of alienation and of possible transformation (Lefebvre 1947), and Michel de Certeau described the "tactics" by which ordinary people make spaces habitable within structures they do not control (de Certeau 1980). Beach City's economy of small proprietors, teenage service workers, and off-season precarity is rendered with a specificity unusual in children's animation, and its people, Lars and Sadie at the Big Donut, the Pizza family, Greg at his car wash, are drawn with the

kind of attention that Iris Murdoch placed at the center of moral life. Murdoch argued that morality consists less in dramatic choices than in the patient, loving attention through which we come to see others justly (Murdoch 1970). Steven's moral education is Murdochian. He becomes good by attending to people, and the episodes that seemed to delay the plot are the scenes of that attention.

6.2 Chosen Kinship and the Three Comothers

Steven is raised by three non-biological guardians, Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearl, in a beach house built against the face of the Crystal Temple, while his father lives in a van nearby; the household later absorbs Peridot, Lapis Lazuli, Bismuth, and a pink lion. Kath Weston's *Families We Choose* (1991) documented the kinship that lesbian and gay communities organized around choice, love, and commitment rather than blood, and Donna Haraway's injunction to "make kin, not babies" (Haraway 2016) extended the principle into a program for a damaged planet. The Crystal Gems are a chosen family of this kind, and the architecture of their home is symbolic: a domestic space laid over a martial and sacred one, as if the Temple's war had been domesticated into a household.

The closest literary precedent is Marge Piercy's *Woman on the Edge of Time* (1976), whose utopian community of Mattapoisett raises each child with three "comothers," none of them the child's biological parent and any of them of any sex, precisely in order to break the possessiveness of the biological family. Steven's three Gem guardians are Piercy's comothers realized, and the series shares Piercy's conviction that the multiplication of parental bonds dilutes possession without diluting love. It also records the costs that Piercy's utopia did not dwell on. The Gems' collective parenting left gaps that none of them saw as hers to fill; *Future*'s "Mr. Universe" makes those gaps explicit.

Connie Maheswaran's family supplies the counterpoint. Her mother, a physician, and her father, a security guard, raise her with an anxious protectiveness that the series initially presents as confinement; Connie's arc, and her mother's, move from control toward trust. The two households, Steven's underprotective and Connie's overprotective, map onto the two failures of holding that Winnicott described: impingement, in which the environment intrudes on the child, and failure of provision, in which it does not hold him at all. The "good enough" environment lies between them, and the series' two families converge toward it from opposite directions.

6.3 Connie's Refusal: Agency, the Sword, and the Undone Marriage Plot

Connie is the series' most fully agentic human. A solitary reader when introduced, she takes up Rose's sword and trains as a knight, and she insists, against Pearl's model of sacrificial devotion, on fighting beside Steven for reasons of her own rather than dying for him. The series consistently allows her to be wiser and steadier than its protagonist. Her family's portrayal risks the stereotype of the high-achieving, strictly governed Indian American household; the series mitigates the risk by granting Dr. Maheswaran interiority, error, and growth, and by making Connie a hero whose independence is not a rebellion against her heritage but an expansion of it.

In *Future*'s "Together Forever," Steven, desperate for permanence, proposes marriage. Connie, who loves him, declines: they are sixteen, she is not ready, and his proposal is a symptom of fear rather than a

choice. The narrative upholds her refusal without punishing her for it. Rachel Blau DuPlessis described the strategies by which twentieth-century women writers "wrote beyond the ending" of the nineteenth-century romance plot, whose heroines could conclude only in marriage or death (DuPlessis 1985). Connie writes beyond the ending. Her refusal also completes the series' theory of consent. Ruby and Sapphire's remarriage was meaningful because it could have been refused; Connie's refusal demonstrates that the possibility is real. A world in which a girl's "no" to a boy's romantic declaration is honored as an act of care rather than treated as a wound is the world the fusion episodes had been preparing.

6.4 Little Homeworld: Diaspora, Hybridity, and the Third Space

After the Diamonds' transformation, Gems from Homeworld begin to settle on Earth, founding Little Homeworld beside Beach City and enrolling in Steven's Little Homeschool to learn how to live freely. Stuart Hall argued that diasporic cultural identity is a matter of becoming as well as of being, positioned within history rather than grounded in an essential past (Hall 1990). Homi Bhabha located cultural creativity in the "third space" of enunciation where cultures meet, and described colonial mimicry as producing a subject that is almost the same as the colonizer but not quite, an ambivalence that unsettles authority (Bhabha 1994). Little Homeworld is a third space in Bhabha's sense. Its Gems adopt human jobs, hobbies, and idioms in ways that are earnest, comic, and subtly transformative of the humans who watch them.

The series had anticipated this theme in Peridot, whose devotion to a human television drama in "Log Date 7 15 2" is both a parody of fandom and a portrait of cultural acquisition through media, the way newcomers learn a society's feelings by watching its stories. Gloria Anzaldúa's *Borderlands/La Frontera* (1987) described the border as an open wound and the *mestiza* consciousness formed there as one that tolerates contradiction and ambiguity and refuses to resolve itself into either of the cultures that formed it. Steven, half human and half Gem, and Stevonnie, a single person composed of two, are borderland bodies in Anzaldúa's sense, and Little Homeworld is a borderland community. Chapter Four recorded the limit of the series' imagination here: a settlement of former imperial subjects, warmly received, raises questions of land and consent that the series does not ask. The settlement nonetheless models a hospitality in which neither the host culture nor the newcomers remain what they were.

6.5 Song as Disclosure

The series' songs are not ornaments but its privileged mode of disclosure. Garnet declares her being in "Stronger Than You"; teaches a discipline of mind in "Here Comes a Thought"; Pearl confesses grief in "It's Over, Isn't It" and articulates a sacrificial ideology in "Do It for Her"; Spinel's "Other Friends" and "Drift Away" turn abandonment into address; the closing theme, "Love Like You," heard in fragments over the credits of hundreds of episodes and at full length only near the end, is a confession of the desire to love as one has been loved. Sugar's idiom, inherited from her work on *Adventure Time*, is plain, confessional, and melodically direct, closer to the folk and singer-songwriter traditions than to the ironic patter of most animated musicals, and the series' casting of performers from Broadway, pop, soul, and folk, including Aimee Mann as Opal and Nicki Minaj as Sugilite, makes each fusion a meeting of musical traditions.

Adriana Cavarero's *For More Than One Voice* (2003) argued, against a philosophical tradition that subordinated voice to the meaning of speech, that the voice manifests the uniqueness of the one who

speaks and is always addressed to another, so that vocal expression is inherently relational. The musical duet is fusion's sonic analogue: two unique voices sustaining a single musical line without ceasing to be two. Garnet, whose speaking and singing voice is a third voice distinct from those of Ruby and Sapphire, is the series' vocal ontology made explicit. The song in *Steven Universe* is the moment at which interiority becomes address, and address, in the series' ethics, is the beginning of relation.

6.6 Paired Hands: Production as Fusion

The series was produced in a board-driven system in which storyboard artists, typically working in credited pairs, composed episodes visually from outlines, with supervising directors and Sugar shaping the whole. Each episode is accordingly a fusion of two sensibilities, recognizable to attentive viewers as the distinct drawing and comic styles of particular pairs merging into a single work. Michel Foucault's analysis of the "author function" (Foucault 1969) and Roland Barthes's proclamation of the author's death (Barthes 1967) are usually invoked to dissolve the individual author into discourse; animation demands a more material account, in which authorship is distributed across writers, board artists, designers, voice actors, composers, and animators. The series' practice of fusion was also its practice of making.

> *The series' practice of fusion was also its practice of making.*

That practice had a further dimension. Like most American television animation, the series was animated largely by studios in South Korea, within a transnational division of labor in which conception and execution are geographically separated. A series whose central villain is an empire that separates design from labor and assigns each worker a fixed function was itself produced within a global industry organized on partly analogous lines. The point is not to convict the series of hypocrisy but to note that its utopia of fused, freely chosen collaboration remains, at the level of its own production, partly unrealized, and that its critique of Homeworld implicates, as serious critique always does, the conditions of its own making.

CHAPTER SEVEN

07

Stone and Light

Toward a Lapidary Humanism

THE PRECEDING CHAPTERS have read *Steven Universe* against the traditions it engages. This chapter reverses the direction and asks what the series contributes to those traditions. Its answer is a philosophical anthropology, here named *lapidary humanism*, that resolves a long-standing impasse in humanist and feminist thought, generates an ethics with determinate principles, finds its natural medium in animation, and implies a politics.

7.1 Four Humanisms and Their Impasse

Modern thought offers four principal accounts of the person and of the ground of its dignity, and each fails in a characteristic way. The first is the *humanism of fixed nature*, from Aristotle's rational animal through Aquinas's natural law to Kant's rational being, whose dignity consists in its capacity for autonomous self-legislation. Its strength is a stable ground for respect; its weakness is that it grounds dignity in a capacity, and so excludes whoever lacks the capacity. Eva Feder Kittay, reflecting on her severely cognitively disabled daughter, argued that capacity-based personhood cannot account for the dignity of those who will never be autonomous reasoners (Kittay 1999). Homeworld's ergon-ethics is the degraded political form of this humanism, in which worth is identical with function.

The second is the *humanism of indeterminacy*, from Pico's Adam to Sartre's self-defining existent, in which dignity consists in freedom from any fixed nature. Its strength is emancipatory; its weakness is voluntarism, an image of the self as self-creating sovereign that neglects situation, dependency, and the body's vulnerability, as Beauvoir saw. The third is *antihumanism*: Foucault's announcement, at the close of *The Order of Things* (1966), that "man" is a recent invention that may soon be erased, like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea; Althusser's theoretical antihumanism; Derrida's "The Ends of Man" (1968). Its strength is the exposure of humanism's complicity with domination; its weakness, as Nancy Fraser argued of Foucault, is a normative confusion that leaves critique without grounds (Fraser 1981), a debate that

feminist theory conducted under the heading of the "death of the subject" (Benhabib et al. 1995). The fourth is *posthumanism* and new materialism, from Haraway's cyborg to Rosi Braidotti's zoe-centered affirmative ethics (Braidotti 2013), Barad's agential realism, and Jane Bennett's vibrant matter (Bennett 2010). Its strength is the extension of moral consideration beyond the human and the restoration of matter's agency; its weakness is a tendency to dissolve the person into assemblages in which specific vulnerability and accountability become hard to locate.

The impasse among these positions has a feminist form. The debate over essentialism (Fuss 1989), Spivak's proposal of a "strategic essentialism," the confrontation between Irigaray's philosophy of sexual difference and Butler's theory of performativity, Barad's charge that performativity neglects the agency of matter, and Elizabeth Grosz's corporeal feminism, which pictured body and psyche as two sides of a Möbius strip (Grosz 1994), all circle the same question. How can a theory of the person grant a material, vulnerable, history-bearing reality that is not a social construction, without converting that reality into a destiny that prescribes what the person must be? Non-Western and anticolonial humanisms point toward an answer. The Confucian tradition grounds humaneness (*ren*) in relationships and in a spontaneous compassion that Mencius illustrated with the alarm anyone feels on seeing a child about to fall into a well (Mencius 2A6). Ifeanyi Menkiti described personhood in African thought as processual, something one grows into through community rather than possesses at birth (Menkiti 1984). Fanon closed *The Wretched of the Earth* by calling for a new humanism to replace a European humanism that spoke of man while massacring men, and Sylvia Wynter argued that the Western figure of "Man" had overrepresented itself as the human as such, foreclosing other genres of being human (Wynter 2003). *Steven Universe* proposes such a genre.

7.2 The Thin Essentialism of the Remainder

The Gem's stone is the series' answer to the impasse. It is material, durable, and prior to any social meaning; it can be cracked, shattered, and corrupted; it bears memory, which survives the dispersal of the body and is recovered, as the film shows, even after an attempt at erasure; and it is the locus of accountability, since the person who acted persists through every change of form to answer for what she did. Yet it carries no destiny. The "purpose" for which Homeworld manufactures each type is a social imposition that the Crystal Gems repudiate without ceasing to be what they materially are. The stone is what *remains* when a Gem's form is withdrawn, and it is in this sense a remainder.

This dissertation calls the position the stone represents a *thin essentialism of the remainder*. It is essentialist because it affirms that there is something that persists, can be harmed, and bears history, and that this something is neither a social construction nor a nothing. It is thin because it attributes to that something no telos, no function, and no prescription about what the person should become. It differs from Aristotle and Kant in grounding dignity not in a capacity but in persistence and vulnerability; from Sartre in affirming a something that freedom does not create; from Butler in placing beneath the performative repetitions of the projected body a non-performative remainder; and from Malabou in giving plasticity a limit, since destructive plasticity in the series occurs when the stone itself is assaulted, as corruption is the effect of an attack on the gem. Spinoza's *conatus*, each thing's striving to persevere in its being, describes the stone's persistence; Arendt's natality describes what it makes possible, since the stone is the site of beginnings rather than the seal of a destiny.

The corrupted Gems are the decisive case. Deprived of speech, memory, recognizable form, and every capacity on which a capacity-based humanism would ground respect, they are nonetheless held by the Crystal Gems for millennia as persons awaiting return rather than destroyed as monsters. Their dignity is the dignity of the remainder. The series' eventual cure of corruption risks what Alison Kafer called the "curative imaginary," in which disabled life is valued chiefly as a state awaiting repair (Kafer 2013), and the risk must be acknowledged. But the five-thousand-year holding of the corrupted as persons is a stronger statement than the cure. It grounds respect in what persists, not in what can be done.

The light is the other pole: the projected body through which the person appears, acts, relates, and changes. Light is the medium of what Arendt called the space of appearance, in which persons disclose who they are to others through speech and action (Arendt 1958). It is revisable: a Gem who retreats into her stone may return in a new form. It is relational: the projected body exists for others, and its most remarkable possibility, fusion, is a form held in common. Light without the stone is, as corruption shows, form detached from continuity; the stone without light is petrification. The series' image of the person, condensed into a single formula, is this: *a person is a held form, a revocable projection of light from a wounded stone, sustained in common.*

The term *lapidary* names the craft that mediates stone and light. The lapidary cuts a gem so that its facets will gather and release light, and the art lies in cutting to reveal rather than to shatter. The metaphor marks a distinction the series enforces between the crack, damage done without care, and the facet, a shaping of the stone through relations that increase its capacity to project. A lapidary ethics asks of every relation, institution, and practice whether it facets or cracks those it shapes.

A lapidary ethics asks of every relation, institution, and practice whether it facets or cracks those it shapes.

7.3 The Ethics of the Held Form: Four Principles, Four Pathologies

From this anthropology the series derives four principles, each defined by the pathology that violates it and each traceable to a distinct intellectual genealogy. Table 1 summarizes them; the paragraphs that follow show why they must be held together.

TABLE 1. THE ETHICS OF THE HELD FORM

PRINCIPLE	FORMULATION	PATHOLOGY	VIOLATION IN THE SERIES	FULFILLMENT IN THE SERIES	GENEALOGY
Revocability	A union is legitimate only while those who compose it can withdraw	Captive fusion	Malachite; the Cluster; the Diamonds' unrevocable rule	Garnet's unfusing and remarriage; Connie's refusal	Milton; Cavell; Pateman; Hirschman
Holding	Revision requires an environment that sustains the subject while it is formless	Abandonment, issuing in unheld or destructive plasticity	Spinel's garden; corruption; Lapis's mirror	The bubble; the Cluster in "Gem Drill"; Steven in "I Am My Monster"	Winnicott; Bowlby; Kittay; Malabou
Continuity	Repair must not erase the history inscribed in the stone	Erasure	The Rejuvenator; the myth of Pink Diamond's shattering; White Diamond's bleaching	Truth-telling after "A Single Pale Rose"; restoration by re-enactment in the film	Arendt; Hirsch; Morrison; Tutu
Reciprocity	Care that does not circulate becomes sacrifice	Sacrificial holding	Rose's self-erasure; Pearl's knighthood; Steven in *Future*	The holder held; therapy; Steven's departure	Kittay's doulia; Tronto; Lorde; hooks
(All four)	The person is reduced to assigned function	Petrification	Homeworld's caste order	Era 3; Little Homeworld	Sartre; Beauvoir; Fromm; Wynter

The principles are not independent; each corrects the characteristic distortion of the others. Revocability without holding is abandonment, exit as desertion, and Rose's unilateral exits, by disguise, by staged death, and by self-erasure, are its form. Holding without revocability is captivity, and the bubble that shelters a retreated Gem becomes, in Bismuth's millennia of confinement, a prison. Continuity without revisability is petrification by memory: Jasper, clinging to her devotion to a Diamond she never met, cannot let her history become anything but a destiny. Reciprocity without revocability is enmeshment, the condition of Steven's bond with the Diamonds, whose reformed love remains a love he cannot leave. The held form is the conjunction of all four.

The framework clarifies what the series adds to its sources. Kantian dignity grounds respect in capacity; lapidary humanism grounds it in persistence and holding. Sartrean freedom is unsupported; here revision requires a holding environment. Levinasian responsibility is asymmetrical and infinite; here it must circulate. Butlerian performativity lacks a remainder; here the projected form is anchored in a stone that bears history. Haraway's kin-making and the ethics of care, the closest of the series' interlocutors, are extended in two directions they have tended to underemphasize: care can be captive, which is why it must remain revocable, and care can erase, as the Gems' loving devotion to Steven erased his own needs, which is why it must honor continuity.

7.4 Animation as Lapidary Medium: Plasmaticness, Plasticity, Projection

Sergei Eisenstein, in notes on Disney written in the early 1940s, admired in the early cartoon a quality he called "plasmaticness": the capacity of animated beings to assume any form, a rejection of what he described as once-and-forever allotted form (Eisenstein 1986). Eisenstein read this protean freedom as a compensatory dream produced by a society of standardized, mechanized, and regimented life. Homeworld is the regime of once-and-forever allotted form; the Crystal Gems, shapeshifting, regenerating, and fusing, are plasmatic. The series is a cartoon about the ethics of being a cartoon.

The correspondence extends to the medium's material conditions. The animated body is, in the cinema, literally projected light, and in production it is a design fixed by a model sheet and sustained frame by frame by the labor of many hands. Paul Wells identified metamorphosis as animation's distinctive capacity (Wells 1998), and Walter Benjamin, whose notes on Mickey Mouse are discussed in Esther Leslie's history of animation and the avant-garde (Leslie 2002), saw in the cartoon body's dismemberment and reassembly both a utopian liberation and a premonition of technological violence. The Gem body reproduces the cartoon body's ontology point by point: poofing is the cartoon character's resilience after injury; regeneration is redesign; fusion is the merging of two character designs; corruption is the model sheet's breakdown; the Rejuvenator is a factory reset to the original model. Spinel, whose design evokes the rubber-hose animation of the early 1930s, can be read as the medium's own past personified: the joyously plasmatic playmate of early animation, abandoned in a garden while her successors moved on, returning with a grievance.

Catherine Malabou's plasticity and Eisenstein's plasmaticness name the two faces of form-change that the medium unites, joyous metamorphosis and traumatic re-formation. The series distinguishes them by exactly the criteria of the held form: metamorphosis is plasmatic when it is consented to and held, and destructively plastic when it is imposed and unheld. Sianne Ngai's analysis of the *cute* as an aesthetic of smallness and powerlessness that elicits both tenderness and aggression (Ngai 2012) completes the account. The series' rounded, soft, cute style is turned against the domination cuteness invites. Pink Diamond was the infantilized "little" Diamond; Steven was the Gems' cherished small object; and *Future* ends with a protagonist who has grown taller than the role of the cute, and who refuses to remain small for anyone's comfort. Animation, the art of the held, projected, collectively sustained form, is the medium in which lapidary humanism could be thought, because in animation every body is a held form.

7.5 Against the Omelas Settlement: The Child Who Walks Away

Le Guin's "The Ones Who Walk Away from Omelas" (1973) describes a radiant city whose happiness depends on the perpetual misery of one child, locked in a cellar; most citizens accept the bargain, and a few walk away. Beach City's safety, the Crystal Gems' recovery, and the galaxy's peace were built in part on the labor and suffering of a child, a child-soldier and child-savior whose emotional work held together the adults around him. *Future* rewrites Le Guin's parable from the child's position. It is the child who walks away, not into darkness but toward a life of his own, and the community is left not destroyed but obliged to sustain itself without his sacrifice. The Omelas settlement is refused from the cellar.

Lee Edelman argued that political life is organized by "reproductive futurism," a fantasy of the future embodied in the figure of the Child, to which queerness, as the refusal of futurity, is opposed (Edelman 2004). Rose's sacrifice is reproductive futurism literalized: the mother ceases so that the Child, who is the future, may live, and the series' adults organize their hopes around him. José Esteban Muñoz answered Edelman by describing queerness as a horizon, a "not yet here" toward which hope reaches, drawing on Ernst Bloch's concrete utopia (Muñoz 2009; Bloch 1954–1959). The series sides with Muñoz but adds a turn neither theorist anticipated. The Child himself must be freed from being the future in order to have one. *Future*'s title is in this sense critical, and its final episode, "The Future," is the moment at which Steven ceases to be the community's future and begins his own.

Jacqueline Rose argued that children's fiction is constitutively a construction of the child for adult desire, so that it is, in a strict sense, impossible (Rose 1984). *Steven Universe* is a children's fiction that eventually exposes its protagonist as the fantasy-child of the adults within it, and perhaps of its audience, and then lets him refuse that role. Martin Hägglund's argument that care and meaning depend on finitude, since an eternal life would make nothing urgent (Hägglund 2019), and Beauvoir's novel *All Men Are Mortal* (1946), whose immortal protagonist finds every choice drained of meaning, illuminate the series' final ethical gesture. The immortal Gems learned to care through their encounter with mortal beings; Rose chose a finite son; and the son, at the end, chooses an ordinary, finite life whose value lies in its being his.

7.6 The Lapidary Polis: Exit, Voice, and Revocable Belonging

Albert O. Hirschman's *Exit, Voice, and Loyalty* (1970) distinguished two responses to institutional decline, leaving and protesting, and showed that institutions are healthiest when both remain available, with loyalty modulating the choice between them. The series' political characters map onto Hirschman's terms. Rose chose exit, unilaterally and through erasure; Bismuth chose voice in its most violent form; Pearl chose loyalty without voice. Steven's arc passes through all three: loyalty to his mother's mission, voice addressed at last to the Diamonds, to his guardians, and to his father, and finally exit. But his exit, unlike his mother's, has a return address. He leaves without severing, the community remains, and the bond survives its loosening. This is *revocable belonging*: membership that can be left without being destroyed and resumed without being coerced.

The lapidary polis, as the series implies it, would satisfy the four principles institutionally. It would make association revocable, so that no member is held by force and none is punished for leaving. It would build holding institutions, public infrastructures of care in which, as Kittay's doulia requires and Tronto's caring democracy proposes, those who care are themselves cared for. It would maintain institutions of continuity, archives, memorials, and truth-telling processes that refuse erasure, of the kind transitional justice has developed. And it would distribute care so that no office, whether sovereign, savior, or Diamond, absorbs the community's dependence into a single person. Iris Marion Young's ideal of city life as "the being together of strangers," a form of social differentiation without exclusion (Young 1990), describes the texture of such a polity, and Beach City beside Little Homeworld is the series' image of it. Le Guin's Anarres in *The Dispossessed* (1974), an anarchist society that develops its own petrifications, is a reminder that such a polity would remain, in Le Guin's phrase, an ambiguous utopia.

7.7 Objections and Limits

Seven objections must be weighed. First, a feminist series has a boy at its center, and the stories of women and nonbinary characters are frequently mediated through his perspective. The series partly answers the objection by thematizing it, since *Future* reveals the cost to everyone of making Steven the center, and by granting Pearl, Garnet, Lapis, Amethyst, and Connie arcs of their own; the structural limit nonetheless remains. Second, as Chapter Four argued, the reconciliation with the Diamonds violates the series' own principle of revocability. Third, the series' healing powers risk the curative imaginary, a risk mitigated but not eliminated by *Future*'s non-curative ending and by the off colors, whose difference is sheltered rather than corrected. Fourth, therapeutic individualism threatens to privatize political trauma, a danger the series addresses but cannot wholly escape within its genre.

Fifth, the series' racial politics combine a notably diverse cast and human community with chromatic allegories, White Diamond and the off colors among them, that risk abstracting race into metaphor in the manner of much fantasy fiction. Garnet, voiced by Estelle, risks in her early stoicism the schema of the "strong Black woman" that Michele Wallace and Melissa Harris-Perry analyzed (Wallace 1979; Harris-Perry 2011); the series complicates the schema by revealing Garnet as a relationship that can break, grieve, and need, but the risk is real. Sixth, the series was produced within a corporate cable network and was, by report, at times edited for broadcast in some international markets where same-gender affection is restricted; its utopianism was bounded by the institutions that carried it. Seventh, one may object that a children's series is not philosophy. The answer is Cavell's and also that of the philosophy-for-children tradition of Matthew Lipman and Gareth Matthews, which holds that children ask philosophical questions in earnest (Matthews 1980). The series' audience includes the very subjects whose dependence, vulnerability, and claims to consent its ethics concerns.

The framework proposed here has limits of its own. Lapidary humanism is derived from a fiction whose ontology makes coercion visible and consent legible, as real social life rarely does; its principles require translation into institutions that can detect captive fusion where it does not show. Its thin essentialism could be misused to ground fixed identities, and must therefore be held to its own constraint: the stone bears history and vulnerability, but prescribes nothing.



A Face in Stone at the Edge of the Sea

MICHEL FOUCAULT CLOSED *The Order of Things* by wagering that "man," a recent invention of the human sciences, might soon be erased like a face drawn in sand at the edge of the sea. For half a century the image has served as the emblem of antihumanism: the sovereign subject of modern thought, washed away by the tide of structures, discourses, and powers that exceed it. *Steven Universe* opens on a different face at a different shore. Above Beach City, carved into the seaside cliff that houses the Crystal Temple, stands a colossal, many-armed figure in stone, whose likeness the finale discloses in Obsidian, the fusion of Steven, Garnet, Amethyst, and Pearl. It is a face at the edge of the sea that the sea does not erase. It is not the face of "man," the sovereign individual whose disappearance Foucault foresaw, but the face of a fusion: a person composed of many, sustained by their continuing consent, carved in a material that bears the marks of its history without being bound by them.

This dissertation has argued that the face in the cliff is the series' answer to the antihumanist challenge, and that the answer is a genuine contribution to philosophical anthropology. The humanism that survives the death of "man" is neither a restoration of the sovereign subject nor a dissolution of the person into assemblages. It is what the preceding chapters have called *lapidary humanism*: the account of the person as a held form, a revocable projection of light from a wounded stone, sustained in common. Its ground is a thin essentialism of the remainder, which affirms a durable, vulnerable, history-bearing core while denying that this core prescribes a destiny. Its ethics is organized by four principles, revocability, holding, continuity, and reciprocity, whose joint violation the series names, in the figure of Homeworld, as petrification.

The study's specific contributions may be stated briefly. First, it has shown that fusion converts consent from a normative into an ontogenetic category, and that the series' fusion episodes articulate, with a systematicity difficult to attribute to chance, the conditions of legitimate union that contemporary consent theory has had to assemble piecemeal. Second, it has read the revelation of Rose Quartz's identity as a problem of matrilineal inheritance, resolved neither by repudiation nor by redemption but by natality:

the stone carries continuity, not identity, and the son is a beginning rather than a continuation. Third, it has tested the series' nonviolent reconciliation with the Diamonds against the strongest anticolonial objections and concluded, by way of immanent critique, that the series itself supplies the criterion, revocability, by which its political settlement falls short. Fourth, it has read *Steven Universe Future* as the series' critique of its own savior ethic, in which the Levinasian subject of infinite responsibility is corrected by the reciprocity of care, and the Omelas settlement is refused from the position of the child. Fifth, it has argued that animation, the art of the projected, revisable, collectively sustained body, is the medium in which this humanism becomes thinkable.

Placed among the works of feminism and humanism with which it has been compared, the series occupies a distinctive position. Against the cultural feminism of *Herland*, it refuses to equate the feminine with the benign. With Beauvoir, Lorde, hooks, and Benjamin, it locates freedom and love in mutual recognition rather than possession. With Ruddick, Kittay, and Tronto, it insists that the caregiver must herself be cared for. With Anzaldúa, Haraway, and Butler, it refuses purity of kind. With Pico and Sartre, it denies that any being is made for a purpose; with Arendt, it holds that every birth is a beginning. What it adds to all of them is an image, rigorously worked out across years of serial narrative, of a person who is neither fixed nor formless, and of a community whose bonds are strong precisely because they can be loosened.

Three lines of further inquiry follow. The first is comparative. The framework proposed here invites application to the serialized animation that followed the series, including ND Stevenson's *She-Ra and the Princesses of Power* (2018–2020) and Dana Terrace's *The Owl House* (2020–2023), in which questions of redemption, chosen family, and the revocability of imperial loyalty recur. The second is institutional. The principle of revocable belonging requires translation into political and legal forms capable of detecting captive union where, unlike in the series, it does not show on the surface of bodies. The third is empirical. Whether the series' ontology functions, as this dissertation has proposed, as a pedagogy of consent for the children and nonbinary viewers for whom fusion was in part imagined is a question for audience research rather than for textual analysis.

The series ends not with a battle, a coronation, or a wedding, but with a departure. Steven, having said his farewells, leaves Beach City to discover what his life might be when it is no longer organized by the needs of others. The ending enacts each principle of the held form at once. His leaving is revocable belonging, an exit with a return address. It is possible because he has, at last, been held. It is undertaken with his history acknowledged rather than erased. And it releases the community from a sacrifice it had not known it was demanding. Behind him, the face in the cliff remains at the edge of the sea, where the tide comes in and goes out and does not wash it away. Foucault's face in the sand marked the end of a humanism founded on the sovereign individual. The face in the stone marks the possibility of another: a humanism of persons who are made of many, who can come apart without being destroyed, and who are, for as long as they consent to be, held.

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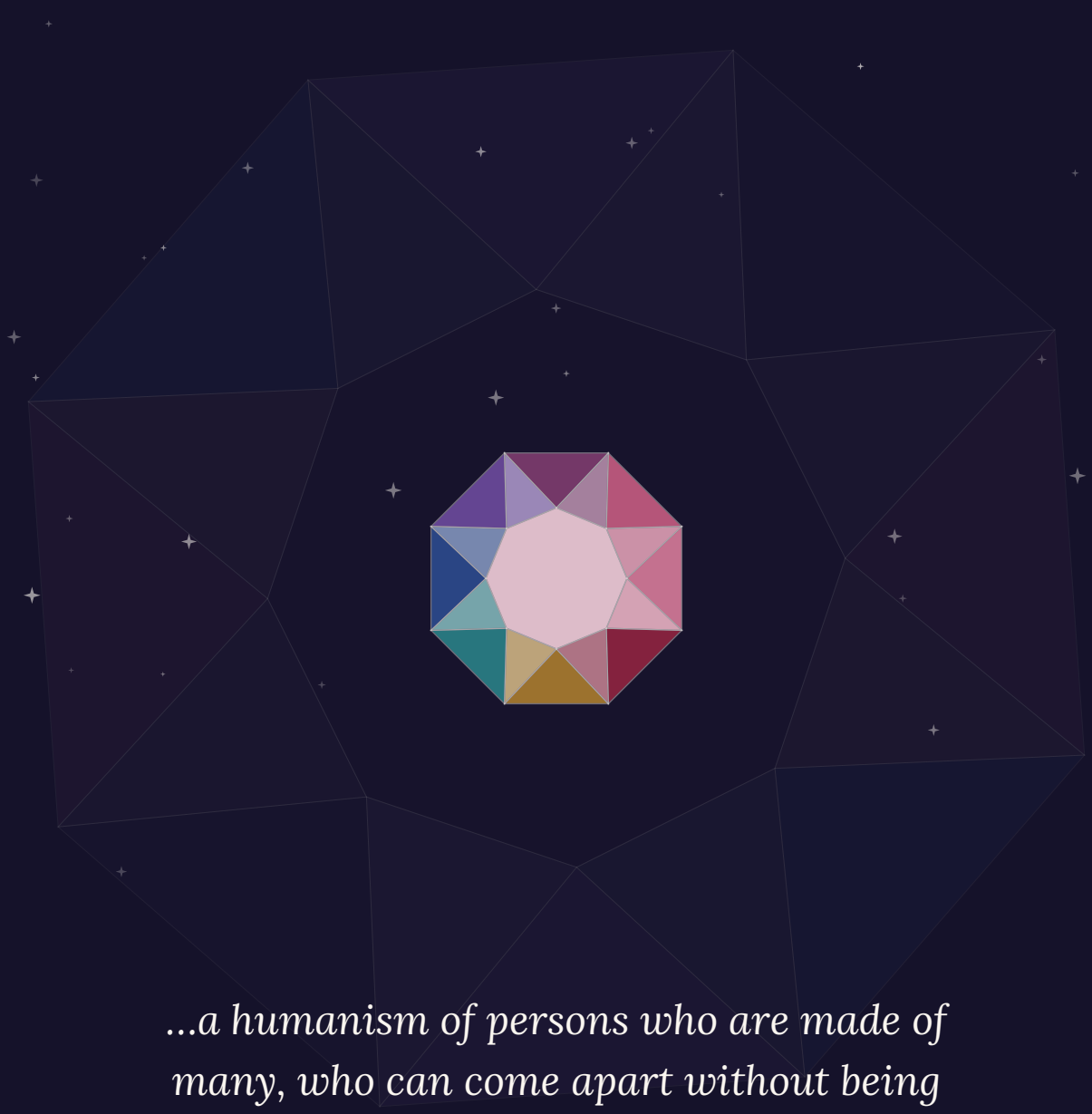
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Keywords

Steven Universe · *Steven Universe Future* · Rebecca Sugar · animation studies · children's television · philosophical anthropology · lapidary humanism · ethics of the held form · thin essentialism · petrification · fusion · consent · ontogenesis · relational ontology · intra-action · individuation · composite individuals · mature love · mutual recognition · the Third · social contract · sexual contract · comedy of remarriage · Chalcedonian union · matrilineal inheritance · matricide · postmemory · reparative reading · Kleinian psychoanalysis · natality · forgiveness and promise · feminist ethics of care · doulia · holding environment · destructive plasticity · plasmaticness · trauma studies · disenfranchised grief · affect theory · nonviolence · decolonization · politics of recognition · restorative justice · necropolitics · coloniality · disability studies · curative imaginary · queer theory · queer futurity · reproductive futurism · chosen kinship · nonbinary gender · Black feminist thought · mestiza consciousness · diaspora and hybridity · feminist speculative fiction · magical girl anime · existentialism · Renaissance humanism · posthumanism · new materialism · exit, voice, and loyalty



...a humanism of persons who are made of many, who can come apart without being destroyed, and who are, for as long as they consent to be, held.

STONE AND LIGHT